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B. USE HB PENCIL ONLY. C. SHADE BOXES LIKE THIS:

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Please do not make any marks in this box

3) DISABILITY	
Blind	☐
Dumb	☐
Deaf	☐
Others	☐

4) STATE OF ORIGIN	
NIGERIAN ONLY	
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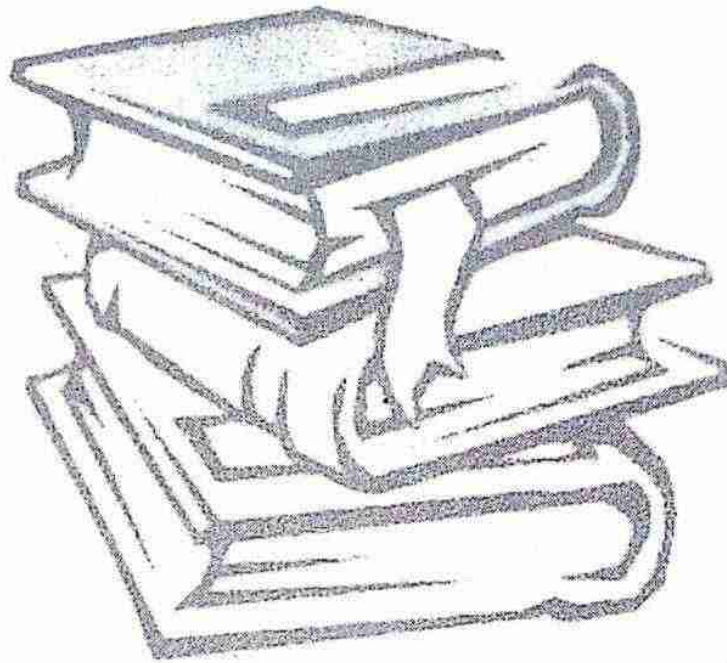
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GRADE (CODE)	
A B C D E F G H I J K L M N O P Q R S T U V W X Y Z	

A-Z

of

JAMB's Use of English



**A to Z
of JAMB's
USE of ENGLISH**

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DEDICATION

Dedicated to my mother, Mrs A.I. Ashade, who, with her late husband, my dear father, taught us all, children, English Grammar from infancy... to mark the occasion of her 80th birthday and celebrate her life as an educationist.

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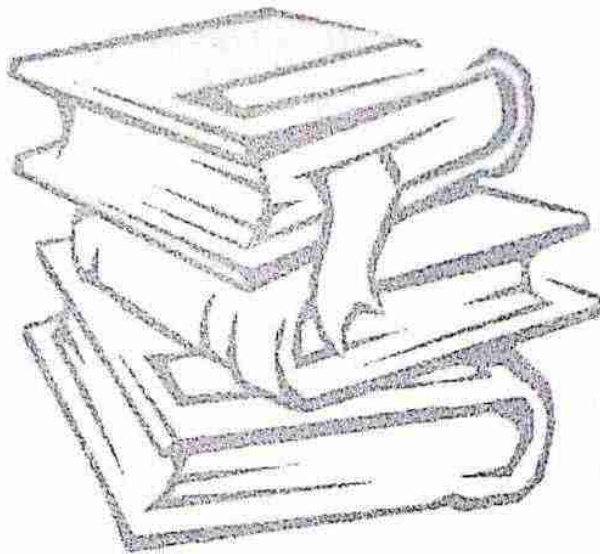
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A to Z of JAMB's
Use of English



SECTION ONE
LEXIS AND STRUCTURE

THE BASIC STRUCTURE OF ENGLISH

Let us start examining aspects under lexis and structure by looking at the basis of grammar.

Parts of speech, that is, nouns, pronouns, verbs, adverbs etc., are actively involved in forming correct English sentences. To form an English clause (sentence), the following elements should be present:

1. SUBJECT(S)

A Subject is the person who performs an action. It may also be the person, thing or place, being talked about, e.g.

- (a) Mercy killed the goat (the person who performs the action **killed** is **Mercy**).
- (b) **The table** is large. What is the subject here?
It is **The table**.

Although **the table** does NOT perform any action, it is the thing being **talked about**. A subject may be either of the following:

- (a) Noun
- (b) Pronoun

So, to form a subject, you could say **Ade** or **He**.

The boy or **He**, **Sade** or **She**, **The girls** or **They**.

My friends and I or **We**, **The water** or **It**. **The Chair** or **It** etc. So, learn this; I will still ask you to name a subject.

2. PREDICATOR(P)

The second element of a clause you must have is the predicator. To put it simply, this refers to **Verbs**. If there is no verb in a sentence, the sentence will be meaningless, senseless and useless. But if

the ONLY word that makes a sentence is a verb, it is still a very sensible sentence. So, you see how very important the verb is.

Now, after giving the subject, e.g. He/She/They/You/I/The girls/ The table etc., the next thing is the verb (P). You can choose one of the following categories of verbs:

- (i) **lexical verb** alone, e.g. goes, dances, speak etc.
- (ii) **modal auxiliary + lexical verb**, e.g. will go/can dance/ shall speak/
- (iii) **anomalous + lexical**, e.g. has eaten/ have gone/ had spoken
- (iv) **primary auxiliary + lexical**, e.g. is going/ are speaking/ were beaten/ are reading etc.
- (v) **anomalous** alone, e.g. has/have/had

Now what I'm saying is this: Subject + any of these five categories of verb. So, let us do it together below:

Subject		Verb (Predicator)	
1.	He)	1.	Type 1 above: (lexical verb alone) e.g. Goes = He goes.
2.	She)	2.	Type 2 above: will (modal auxiliary) + go = will go e.g. She will go.
3.	It)	3.	Type 3 above: has (anomalous) + gone = It has gone.
4.	We)	4.	Type 4 (above): are (primary auxiliary + lexical) We are going.
5.	He /has/a book. Now type 5 (anomalous, above) e.g. He has ...		

Do you now understand? So, up to this point, you have learnt how to arrange the subject and predicator (verbs).

Now, you should be careful to ensure that after you have chosen a subject, simply choose any one of the five patterns of verbs outlined above.

After **Subject** is **Predicator**. After predicator is **Complement**. What is the **complement** in a clause?

3. **COMPLEMENT (C)**

You see, dear, when an action takes place, that action may go or pass from the doer (subject) to a receiver of the action.

So, whoever or whatever receives the action under **P** (Predicator) is the **complement**, e.g. "He beats Ola." Now, let us analyse:

Beats is the predicator (it is a lexical verb). Now, who receives the action of *beats*? Yes, **Ola**. What are the complements in the following clauses?

- (a) She likes oranges.
- (b) We all know the answer.
- (c) They need some polish.

The complements are (A) **oranges** (B) **the answer** (C) **some polish**

So, you see that a complement can be a single word. It may also be a group of words. For now, we will not say more than that. After the **complement** is **Adjunct** which is the last of the four elements: SPCA.

4. **ADJUNCT (A)**

Adjunct stands for Adverbs and Adverbials. Remember, an adverb tells us a lot of things about the verb. For example, it tells us the **time**, the **place**, the **reason**, the **degree**, the **concession**, the **frequency** etc of the action. Consider this:

Johnson speaks English } quickly.
 } everyday.
 } at 8 o'clock.
 } very well.
 } because he knows grammar.
 } although he is a Yoruba man.

So, now, let us analyse:

Johnson	=	Subject
speaks	=	Predicator
english	=	Complement
quickly	=	Adjunct (Adverb of manner — the manner in which he speaks)
everyday	=	Adjunct (Adverb of frequency — how often he speaks English)
at 8 O'clock	=	Adjunct (Adverb of time — the time at which he speaks)
very well	=	Adjunct (Adverb of degree... Very. He does not speak English well but <i>very well</i>) The word "very" shows the high degree.
because he knows grammar	}	Adjunct (Adverbial clause of reason) Why does he speak English? It is "because he knows grammar".

although he is

a Yoruba man = Adjunct (Adverbial clause of concession)

So, you should not write any sentence, which has no subject or predicator. I have stressed that, of SPCA, the "P" is the MOST important. When you make a clause, start with S + P (under "P" choose one of the five patterns of arranging verbs. If you find it

necessary, add more information about the action, then add the adjunct. So, we can have the following patterns:

S	P	C	A	
Nath	goes.	_____	_____	= SP
Nath	goes	home.	_____	= SPC
Nath	goes	home	everyday.	= SPCA

But you cannot have only S, e.g. **Nath** or only C, e.g. **Home** or only A, e.g. **Everyday**. You can however have only "P" as in a command to somebody:

Go! Speak! Stand! To analyse these, now we believe the subject will be, **YOU**. Then, **go**, **speak** and **stand** will be **P = SP**.

N.B. **Go, speak, stand, read, walk**, etc. are all lexical verbs.

Lexical verbs must agree with the subjects in number as shown in the table below:

	Singular	Plural
(a)	goes	go
(b)	speaks	speak
(c)	stands	stand
(d)	walks	walk

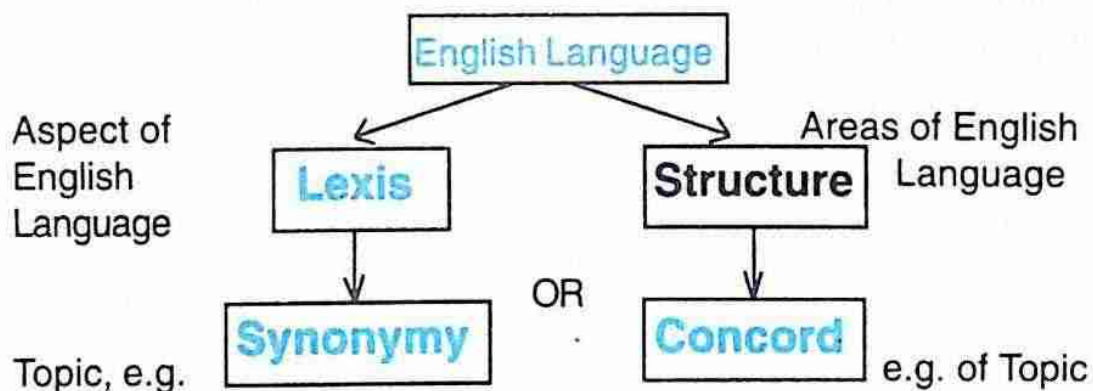
GRAMMAR

What is **Lexis**? What is **Structure**?

You have often heard or sat for examinations in English, involving **Lexis** and **Structure**, but do you know what these mean?

Let me quickly tell you that, in any English Language examination you sit for, when you see the questions, you should be able to say, "Oh! this question is from the topic on Concord or, that is from Determiners or this is from Comparison." Believe me sincerely, if you do not know the topic from which a question is taken, it is only by chance that you will get the correct answer.

In this connection, you should be able to say, "Oh!, this question is from the area of **Lexis** and the topic is... ." or, "this question is from the area of **Structure** and the topic is... ."



I repeat: if you do not know if a question is on Lexis or Structure; or you do not know what topic under 'Lexis' or what topic under 'Structure' it is, then the answer is not yours!

The English Language – or rather, its sentences are predicated on a system of the relationship between words. Individual words in a

language are called **lexical items** – a term from **Lexis**. So, words like:

Teacher	(noun)
he	(pronoun)
go	(verb)
quickly	(adverb)
handsome	(adjective)
oh!	(interjection)
under	(preposition)
and	(conjunction)

are all items of **lexis** or **lexical items**

The section on Lexis in an English examination is to test candidates on their knowledge of:

- | | | |
|-----|----------------------------------|---------------|
| (a) | the appropriate use of words | (diction) |
| (b) | meanings of words | (semantics) |
| (c) | word opposites | (antonymy) |
| (d) | similar words | (synonymy) |
| (e) | similar-sounding words | (homophones) |
| (f) | the company that words keep | (collocation) |
| (g) | words with more than one meaning | (polysemy) |

So, a test on lexis will involve aspects such as **nearest-in-meaning-to**, **opposite-in-meaning-to**, **most-appropriate-word** type of questions.

You are always warned not to regard the dictionary as the final authority or pontiff on the meaning of words. The circumstances

and “environment” of a word are the best, impervious authority and “oracle” on the meaning of that word.

You are to read more on how to handle questions on Lexis, under the topic: WORD FACTORY, beginning on page 137 of this book.

STRUCTURE

Structure refers to the definite, established rules of a language, for the combination of words in that language to form meaningful utterances. In this case, words are put together in orderly ways.

A test of structure, therefore, is an examiner’s attempt to determine whether you know the rules for combining lexical items (words) together, without striking an error. A structure question is one like this:

Many a _____ / _____ her.

- (a) student/know
- (b) student/knows
- (c) students/know
- (d) students/knows

There is a universal rule (known all over the world in language circles) for resolving a question like this. Another is:

He regretted that he had only _____ information about her, when we asked about her whereabouts from him.

- (a) a little
- (b) a few
- (c) little
- (d) few
- (e) some

As said before, the first step is to determine the topic on which the question is set.

HOW TO DETERMINE TOPICS

You can know the topic from which a particular question is taken by following these steps:

- (a) Analyse, grammatically, the statement/sentence of the question and see where the dash (“-”) falls. For example,

Many a _____ / _____ her

To analyse this, we should find the **Subject(s)**, the **Predicator(P) (verb)**, the **Complement(C)** and the **Adjunct(A)**. You know what each of these elements **SPCA** means or stands for – don't you? Yes!

To arrive at the subject(s), you ask the question: **Who/What** did the action in the sentence? In the case of the above question statement, **Who/What** did what to her?

So, the subject is, **many a student** or **students**. Now, you see that a part of the subject forms the position of the gap, that is, the dash “-” appears in the position of the subject. That is fact one. Therefore, in determining the topic, consideration must include the subject.

Further, you will look for the predicator (do not forget that what we are doing is, analysing the morphology of the sentence of the question). The predicator, verb, is also missing in the question. It should have appeared at the position of the second —, in the question.

The next is the complement(C) **-her**. Next is the adjunct. (You know the Adjunct(A) is not compulsory in a clause, so if it is not there, there is no cause for alarm). So, the question again:

Many a _____ / _____ her.

Now, we can analyse like this:

Subject(S)	Predicator(P)	Complement(C)	Adjunct(A)
Many a -----	-----	her	Ø

Since the gaps come under both subject and predicator, it is the **subject** and **predicator, working together**, that will provide your answer.

STEP B: You must go back to the 25 to 30 rules that have been given on **concord** in this book. Do not forget that the English Language, in particular, is a system of rules.

I will leave you to answer the question (above) by yourself after reading through the treatise of **CONCORD** in this book.

CONCORD

Concord means **agreement between the subject and verb or between a verb and other elements of clause structure**. It is my belief that you have not forgotten what the subject and verb mean.

There are several methods of framing questions under concord, based on the many rules governing the topic.

Now, for example, do you say:

- (a) They suggest he **go** away or he **goes** away?
- (b) Many a girl **likes** or **like** him?
- (c) My club **meet** or **meets** everyday?
- (d) The boy, with this parents, **go** or **goes** to farm?
- (e) The teachers, the principals, our parents or Mr Olu **is** or **are** to blame?

These, and many more, are structures under concord and unless you know the rules that govern a particular structure, you will go on guessing your answer.

Note: Singular verbs include: **is, was, has**, and action verbs which have **s** at the back, e.g. **goes, dances, writes, knows, speaks** etc.

Plural verbs:- These include: **are, were, have**, and action verbs which do not have **s** at the back, e.g. **dance, write, know, speak** etc.

Let us look at certain types of concord.

1. **Subject/Verb Concord**

When the subject is singular, the verb should be singular, too.

He (singular subject) **goes** (singular verb), not: **He go** (plural verb). Also, when the subject is plural, the verb should be plural.

The boys (plural subject) **go** (plural verb), not:

The boys (plural subject) + **goes** (singular verb).

2. Subject/Object Concord

Rule: When **everyone**, **everybody** etc. are used, the object will be **his/her** i.e. "his or her" not **their**, as in:

Everybody knows **his** or **her** name, not:

Everybody knows **their** name (this is not acceptable in formal English Language).

3. Mandative Subjunctive Concord

Rule: When **recommendation**, **resolution**, **demand**, **wish**, **suggestion** or **prayer** is involved in a sentence, the verb of the clause should be plural, whether the subject is singular or plural, e.g.

"It has been **recommended** that he **go** (not **goes**) away." It is so because the statement borders on **recommendation**. For analysis, this is the full version of the sentence above:

"It has been recommended that he (should) go."

It is only that, **that** has been removed and you still remember the rule that says, when a modal auxiliary, such as **shall – should, may - might, can - could** etc..., is used, the next verb should be plural. A verb without **s** should appear here.

Other examples are:

I pray that God help (not: **God helps...**)

We resolved that the secretary resign (not: **resigns**).

The principal **suggests** Olu **leave** the school (not: Olu **leaves**...).

We **demand** she **pay our** money (not: she **pays**).

It is not only when the words **recommend, wish, pray, suggest, resolve** etc. appear that this rule will hold, but also it will hold even if there are no such words, but if the word used instead suggests the meaning of any of the above listed, e.g. **We insist** or **require** or **move... that he resign** (not: **resigns**).

This is so since all the four verbs mean "resolution" or "demand". So, watch out for other words that seem to mean any of the above and then apply the rule.

4. A-Pair-of Concord

When **A-pair** of trousers/shears etc. is used, it attracts a singular verb, such as, **is, was, has, goes, dances** e.g. A pair of shears **lies** on the kitchen shelf.

5. The Principle of Proximity

This principle simply states that when there is a list of nouns or pronouns at the level of the subject, it is the nearest noun or pronoun to the position of the verb that will determine the choice of the verb. What, for example, is the answer here?

If Shade passes her examination, her teachers, her friends, Sola or I _____ to praise. (a) is (b) are (c) am (d) has (e) will have to.

C is correct because, at the subject level, we have **her teachers, her friends, Sola and I** (four different people). Which of them counts as our subject? Of course, the nearest to the gap which is **I**.

So if **I** is our subject, **am** is the verb that goes with it. It would be a different case if the question came thus:

If Shade passes her examination, her teachers, her friends or Sola — to be praised for it.

What will the answer be?

Here, **is** would be the answer because **Sola** will be our subject. So, it would easily be; Sola **is** (not: **are**).

6. **Many — a Concord**

Where **Many – a** is used, it should be immediately followed by a **singular noun** and a **singular verb**, e.g.

- (a) **Many a + boy** (not: boys) **is** (not: **are**) **here**.
- (b) **Many a + student** (not: students) **speaks** (not: **speak**)
bad English expressions.

The real meanings of statements (a) and (b) are “many students”, “many boys”.

7. **Collective Noun Concord (NOTIONAL CONCORD)**

A collective noun is a word which stands for many units that constitute that single word, e.g. **congregation** = worshippers, **audience** = people who watch a programme, **class** = students, **clergy** = religion officers etc. You have to be careful here:

Let us take a question from the “PCE” 1990, question 41: “My Club _____ (a) is meeting (b) met (c) meets (d) meet twice in a month.

First, **Club** is a collective noun for **members**. So, we can break that **club** and say, **Members of this organisation + meet** (not: **meets**).

But there are certain situations when a singular verb will go with a collective noun. The principle is this: If the collective

noun performs action, a plural verb follows, but if not, a singular verb follows, e.g.

- (a) **Our Club** (physical building of our organisation) is ten years old today.

The statement does not imply that our club performs any action. So we use a singular verb. But look at this:

- (b) **Our Club** _____ going to Ibadan tomorrow.

Here, club refers to the members within the organisation and since they are **going** (performing an action), we would not use **is** but **are** in compliance with the rule.

Can you attempt this?

The audience _____ partial in their judgement of the beauty queens. (a) is (b) are

The answer is are. Audience (the collective noun) **perform action** of passing judgement.

8. **"More-than" Concord**

When **More-than** is used, the word or number that comes after **more-than** will determine the next verb, e.g.

- (a) More than **two oranges** are here.
(b) More than **one orange** is here.

This is because **two** attracts **are**, but in (b), **one** comes after **more-than** and it should attract **is**. Do not think that, because **more than one** means **at least two**, you will use a plural verb after.

9. **Parenthesis in Concord**

Parenthetic statement is additional statement to what has already been said before. It is usually put in bracket but, for examinations, the questioner may not put the bracket so that you would not easily determine where the parenthetic statement starts and ends.

Caution: A parenthetic statement should NOT be considered in choosing the verb that will follow, e.g.

The salesman, not many of his representatives, _____ here now. (a) are (b) was (c) came (d) is

Answer = is. This is because, **not many of his representatives** is just a parenthesis. Therefore, it should be totally ignored. **The salesman** is therefore the subject and, since it is singular, we should choose the present singular verb **is**.

Consider this: **The principal**, not his students, _____ in the hall. (a) are (b) is

Answer = is. Just put a bracket from **not** and close it after **students**, to show that **not his students** is just parenthesis — it has nothing to do with choosing the verb.

10. Indefinite Pronoun Concord

When any of the following words is used, you should use a **singular verb**:

- (a) everyone, everything, everybody, everywhere
- (b) no one, nothing, nobody, nowhere,
- (c) anyone, anything, anybody, anywhere
- (d) someone, something, somebody, somewhere ... each, e.g. Nothing **goes** (not: **go**). Everybody **thinks** (not: think).

11. Accompaniment Concord

When any of **as well as**, **no less than**, **together with**, **in association with**, **alongside**, **with**, **including**, **in collaboration with**, **like**, **as much as** etc. is found, the

subject of the clause would be the noun or pronoun that comes before the marker of accompaniment, e.g.

- (a) Toyin, **as well as** her sisters, _____ pretty. (a) is (b) are
Answer = is. This is because **Toyin** is the noun that comes before **as well as** and it is therefore the subject. **Toyin** is singular, so **is** is chosen.

- (b) The little boys **alongside** their father _____ here.
(a) is (b) are

Answer – b. This is because **The little boys** comes before **alongside** and is therefore the subject. The subject is plural and **are** is plural too.

12. Relative Concord

When any of **who, which, that, whose** refers to a previously mentioned noun or pronoun, it is a relative pronoun, e.g.

One of the women who _____ in the premises _____ been asked to withdraw. (a) sells/has (b) sell/has
(c) sells/have (d) sell/have

Answer = (b). **Who** refers to **women** and **women** attracts **sell**, but **one** of them **has** ... i.e. **one** attracts **has**.

13. Pluralia Tantums

Pluralia tantums are nouns that come in plural forms. Some of these have final **s**, whereas some do not. However, whenever any of the following appears, it must be followed by a singular verb.

- (i) **School Subject:** Physics, Mathematics, Economics, Civics, Statistics etc. (Note that all of them end in **s** but it does not show plurality).

- (ii) **Diseases:** Mumps, Shingles, Measles, Tuberculosis etc.
- (iii) **Games:** Darts, Snakes and Ladders, Skittles, Billiards, Bowls and Draughts.
- (iv) **Book/Magazine titles**, e.g. *A Tale of Two Cities*,
The Children of Ananse, e.g.

The Children of Ananse **is** an interesting book.

The following words also take singular verbs: **news, means, series**, as in:

- (i) **The series of incidents makes me shudder.**
- (ii) **The means of transport hastens travelling.**

Note: There are some nouns that do not appear as singular at all but as plurals and they often attract plural verbs. They are the following:

The middle ages, annals, auspices, bowels, banns, arrears, ashes, arms, (weapons), earnings, entrails, fireworks, funds (money), goods (product), guts, holidays, manners, means, outskirts, pains (discomfort) particulars (documents) quarters (headquarters), regards, remains, riches, savings, spirits, stars, suds, surroundings, thanks, troops, wages and writs.

All of these cannot appear without **s** and, as such attract only **plural verbs**, e.g.

- **The remains** (corpse) of the man **have** (not **has**) been buried.
- Her **manners** are good.

14. **Uncountable Nouns in Concord**

Countable nouns are nouns that can be quantified in units and numbers, e.g. boy-boys, table-tables.

Uncountable nouns – also known as mass-count or non-count nouns are nouns that cannot be quantified in number, e.g. water, information. Below is a list of such categories of nouns.

Uncountable	Countable equivalent
- Mankind	a human being
- Behaviour (not behaviours)	a form of behaviour or two forms of behaviour
- Progress (not progresses)	
- Training (not trainings)	a course of training
- Machinery (not machineries)	a machine/two machines
- Cloth (a pieces of cloth)	five pieces of cloth
- Furniture (not furnitures)	a piece of furniture
- Information (not informations)	a piece of information
- Scenery (a piece of scenery)	
- Work (household work)	a piece of work/job
- Work (public works, e.g. road, housing, transport works)	
- Damage (destruction of a thing, degree/amount of damaged item)	
Damages (money claimed in law by someone as compensation)	
- Equipment (not equipments)	a piece of equipment
- Money (not five monies)	a sum of money or an amount of money
- Duty (money charged on imports not "duties")	an amount of duty

- Capital (money to Economists)	an amount of capital
- Wealth (not Wealths)	a state of wealth
- Data (not Datas)	a piece of data
- Fruit	a piece of fruit
- Luggage	a piece of luggage
- Baggage	a piece of baggage
- News	a piece of news
- Advice (not Advices)	a piece of advice
- Traffic	a flow of traffic / a vehicle
- Knowledge	an amount/piece of knowledge
- Apparatus	a piece of apparatus
- Employment	a job / a piece of work
- Personnel	an employee / a worker
- Staff	a member of staff
- Evidence (never Evidences)	a piece of evidence

Included in this category are all abstract nouns. Remember, abstract nouns are those things which exist but which are not affected by the senses, of touch and sight, i.e. we cannot see or touch them, e.g. happiness, sadness, joy, intelligence, jealousy etc.

Note: All uncountable nouns will avoid **s** at the back, e.g. informations, equipments. Instead, you have five **pieces** of information/ten pieces of equipment. Also, note that the following nouns attract plural verbs:

- **Headquarters:** The headquarters **look** (not looks) palatial.
- **Police:** The police **work** hard (not works), but, that policeman **works** hard.

- **Aircraft:** Aircraft **make** (not makes) travelling easy but, that helicopter/aeroplane/airbus/glider makes travelling easy.
- **Clergy:** The clergy **remain** (not remains) respected in Nigeria, but, that clergyman / priest / monk / Reverend Sister remains respected in Nigeria.
- **Cattle:** Cattle **give** (not gives) bad odour, and a cow gives bad odour.

15. Co-ordinate Concord

When two subjects are joined together by **and**, the verb to be used should be plural, e.g.

Ade and Olu are here.

Jack and Jill **know** (not knows) Jane.

16. Double-title-subject Concord

When two subjects are joined together by **and** but the two subjects refer to only **one person** or **thing**, a **singular verb** should be used, e.g.

Our principal and English Language teacher (here, not two different people but, our principal is also our English Language teacher) **is coming/knows me/has come**.

Consider:

Our principal and the English Language teacher.

This is quite different as **the principal** and **the English Language teacher** are different people.

The use of **the** with the second subject makes a difference + plural verb.

17. **Mathematical Facts**

In matters relating to addition, subtraction and multiplication, problems of concord occur when such mathematical facts are stated. The verb will be any of singular and plural, e.g. Five multiplied by three **is/are** fifteen.

Ten plus ten **is/are** twenty.

Both singular and plural are correct.

18. **Plural Number Concord**

When amount or unit is mentioned such as two hundred times, eight percent, ten metres, the next verb should be singular, e.g. Eight pounds **is** too few to build a house.

19. **Every + Plural Number Concord**

When **every** precedes a plural, the next verb is plural, e.g. Every five gallons of paints bought **carry** (not **carries**) a bonus of an extra gallon. But remember, when **every** appears without any plural number, the verb is singular, e.g.

Every man (not **men**) likes women.

When, however, **and** joins two or more subjects with **every** or **each**, the verb should be **singular** e.g.

Every student and teacher **comes** (not **come**) to school early.

Every man and woman **speaks** well here.

20. **Categorisation Concord**

When a collective name, denoting category (not collective noun) is involved, the verb to be used should be plural.

Such categories include **the gifted, the successful, the rich, the poor, the handicapped, the weak, the wealthy, the young in spirit** etc.

The poor means The poor people.

The handicapped means The handicapped people.

The young are disobedient.

The helpless are left to their fates.

21. **All – Concord**

When **all** appears, it means either **everything** or **all the people**. When **all** means **everything**, the next verb should be **singular** but when **all** means **all the people**, the next verb should be **plural**, e.g.

All **is** well with me (**Everything** is well with me).

All **are** already seated in the hall (**All the people** are already...).

When, however, **all but** is used, the following verb should be **plural**, e.g. **All but** Ade **are** in the **hall**. i.e. Ade is the only one absent.

22. **Either/Neither Concord**

When **either** or **neither** joins two singular nouns together, the verb to be used is **singular**, e.g.

Either Olu or Ola **knows** me/**is** here.

Neither my wife nor her brother **hears** anything/**was** there.

But, when **either** or **neither** joins two subjects (one singular and the other plural), the verb should be chosen by considering the nearer of the two subjects, e.g.

Either Ola or the teachers **know** me. (Note that **teachers** is nearer the verb gap than it is near 'Ola'.)

These rules also apply to sentences where **but** or **but even** joins two subjects, e.g.

Not Lawrence but James **speaks** good English.

Not only Sola but even **teachers laugh** in school.

23. **Each and One of Concord**

Whenever **each** appears in a concord structure, a singular noun + a singular verb will be chosen, e.g.

Each **man** (not **men**) **has** (not **have**).

However, wherever **each of** or **one of** appears, the next noun should be plural but the next verb should be singular, e.g.

Each of the gamblers (not **gambler**) **stands** (not **stand**) a good chance.

24. **Most/Much Concord**

Where **most** appears, the verb will be either singular or plural, depending on whether the referent is a countable or uncountable noun, e.g.

Most of **the boys** **are** ...

Most of the **time** (uncountable) **is**. Wherever **much** is used, the verb of the clause must be singular, e.g. **Much** of the water **has** (not **have**) been spilled.

MODEL QUESTIONS

Model Question 1

The employer, not the salesman and his representative, responsible for the loss. (a) are (b) are being (c) are never (d) have been (e) is

Clue to answer: Read concord rule 9: **Parenthesis in Concord.**

Model Question 2

The benefit one gets from watching plays.....comparable to that found in taking a university course in drama. (a) is (b) was (c) were (d) are (e) are being

Clue to answer: Read rule 1: **Subject/verb concord.**

Model Question 3

If Remi performs poorly in her forthcoming examination then, either her mother or I to blame. (a) must (b) has (c) will be (d) are (e) am

Clue to answer: Read concord rule 22: **Either/Neither Concord.**

Model Question 4

We hold that the nation, both in its public and private sectors, the best consultancy service in all its endeavours. (a) deserve (b) is deserving (c) deserves (d) are deserving (e) richly deserve

Clue to answer: Read concord rule 9: **Parenthesis in Concord.**
The nation is the subject; **both in its public and private sectors** is in parenthesis.

Model Question 5

Each of the contestants a chance to win. (a) has (b) have (c) get (d) gets (e) take

Clue to answer: Read rule 23: **Each Concord.**

Model Question 6

The only set of loudspeakers available to be connected according to the instruction. (a) is (d) are (c) were (d) have

Clue to answer: A set/group is regarded as a single unit, i.e. singular subject.

Model Question 7

In my opinion, neither the players nor the coach praise for the result of the match. (a) deserves (b) deserve (c) are deserving (d) is deserving

Clue to answer: Read concord rule 22: **Either / Neither Concord.**

Model Question 8

Many a candidate to realize the difference between written and spoken English. (a) fails (b) fail (c) have failed (d) is failing

Clue to answer: Read rule 6: **Many – a Concord.**

Model Question 9

All well with Peter. (a) are not (b) have not been (c) were not (d) is not

Clue to answer: Read rule 21: **All – Concord.**

Model Question 10

A Tale of Two Cities the we are studying for the examination. (a) are/novels (b) was/novel (c) were/novels (d) is/novel

Clue to answer: Read rule 13: **Plurality Tantums in Concord.**

Model Question 11

One of the ladies who in the premise been asked to withdraw. (a) sells/ have (b) sell/ have (c) sells/ has (d) sell/ has

Clue to answer: Read rule 12: **Relative Concord.**

Model Question 12

Three quarters of the church painted by members the previous day. (a) were (b) was (c) is (d) are

Clue to answer: Read rule 17: **Mathematical Facts.**

"Three quarters of the church" is however about "Space", an uncountable noun, hence it is regarded as singular. Read also rule 14: **Countable and Uncountable Nouns in Concord.** You may also wish to read rule 7: **Notional Concord.**

Model Question 13

Two young boys have been caught with parts of the stolen machine but admitted stealing it. (a) neither of them has (b) neither of them have (c) none of them has (d) none of them have

Clue to answer: Read rule 22: **Either/Neither Concord.**

Model Question 14

Knowledge of figures of speech as well as of idioms and lexical items in this situation. (a) is tested (b) have been tested (c) are tested (d) were tested

Clue to answer: Knowledge (an uncountable, singular noun) is the subject.

Model Question 15

Each of the candidates that came late to complete
(a) have/this form. (b) are having/these forms. (c) have/these forms.
(d) has/this form.

Clue to answer: Read rule 23.

Model Question 16

Either the chief of the village or the leader of the farmers to
be held responsible for the revolt. (a) were (b) are (c) is (d) have

Clue to answer: Read rule 22: **Either/Neither Concord.**

Model Question 17

We must observe that most of the support by other states
only marginal returns. (a) have yielded (b) yield (c) has yielded (d)
have yield

Clue to answer: Read rule 24. Remember **most of** or **much of** plus
uncountable noun, like **support** above, attracts a singular verb.

Model Question 18

The effort made by the principal to get the students to be serious in
their studies (a) are appreciated. (b) will appreciate. (c) is to
appreciate. (d) is appreciated.

Clue to answer: **Effort** is uncountable, hence, a singular noun.
Read rule 14: **Countable and Uncountable Nouns in Concord.**

Model Question 19

Only observers from the Ministry of Worksallowed into the
conference room. (a) is (b) are (c) have (d) has been

Clue to answer: **Observers** is a plural subject. Read rule 1: **Subject
/ Verb Concord.**

Model Question 20

A panel set up to probe the organisation's activities yet to sit. (a) are (b) is (c) will (d) would

Clue to answer: Read rule 7: Collective Noun (**Notional Concord**).

Model Question 21

Every programming language and software package limitations. (a) have its (b) have their (c) has its (d) has their

Clue to answer: Read rule 19: **Every + Plural number Concord**. In considering the answer, note that every programming language and software package refer to only one thing, as a singular subject. Rule 16 will also lead you to the correct answer.

Model Question 22

Three quarters of the Physics class (a) improve. (b) improves. (c) are improving. (d) is improving.

Clue to answer: Read rule 7: **Notional Concord**.

Model Question 23

A survey of opinions on how pupils feel about their teachers carried out. (a) has been (b) have been (c) are being (d) is been

Clue to answer: Note that **A Survey** is the subject and is singular.

Model Question 24

Our principal and chairman of the occasion just arrived. (a) has (b) having (c) have (d) had

Clue to answer: Read rule 16: **Double-Title-Subject Concord**.

Model Question 25

One of the selective marking of errors. (a) School of thought suggests (b) Schools of thought suggest (c) School of thoughts suggested (d) Schools of thought suggests

Clue to answer: Read rule 23: **Each and One of Concord.**

Model Question 26

The vermin on his bodyhideous. (a) makes the lunatic look (b) make the lunatic look (c) makes the lunatic to look (d) make the lunatic to look.

Clue to answer: **Vermin** is plural already. Read more on “**unmarked plurals**” under the topic “Plural Categories of Nouns”, a sub-topic under “Grammatical Plurals” in this book. You will read about other nouns, e.g. youth, police etc, that do not take ‘s’ to pluralise them.

Model Question 27

The helpless our sympathy. (a) require (b) requires (c) does require (d) do requires

Clue to answer: Read rule 20: **Categorisation Concord.**

Model Question 28

Either Ekaete or you to go. (a) was (b) are (c) has (d) is

Clue to answer: Read rule 5: **The Principle of Proximity.**

Model Question 29

Sixty percent of the unskilled workers yearly by the company. (a) are retained (b) is retained (c) were retained (d) had been retained

Clue to answer: You know 60% of workers means 60 out of 100. So, "Sixty workers", which is the subject, is plural. Read rule 7.

Model Question 30

The director, no less than his workers, to blame. (a) is (b) are (c) were (d) ought

Clue to answer: Read rule 11: **Accompaniment Concord**.

Model Question 31

One of the vice in an interim capacity. (a) president acts (b) presidents act (c) presidents acts (d) presidents acts

Clue to answer: Read rule 23: **Each** and **One of Concord**.

Model Question 32

A sterile range of mountains, broken at intervals by deep rivers, almost the whole of this small state. (a) enclose (b) encloses (c) cover (d) covers

Clue to answer: Read rule 7: Notional Concord. **A range** is a collective noun.

Model Question 33

All the cattle on Lamidi's farm (a) is tick free. (b) are tick-free. (c) is tick-free. (d) are ticks-free.

Clue to answer: Note that **cattle** cannot take an **s** to form its plural and the verb that cattle attracts is always plural. Read more from "unmarked plurals" under the topic **Plural Categories of Nouns** under Grammatical Plurals in this book.

Model Question 34

Two young boys have been caught with parts of the stolen machine but admitted stealing it. (a) neither of them has (b) neither of them have (c) none of them has (d) none of them have

Clue to answer: Read rule 22: **Either / Neither Concord.**

Model Question 35

His chances in the games..... seriously jeopardised. (a) have been (b) has been (c) have being (d) has being

Clue to answer: The subject of this sentence is **his chances**, which is plural. Use rule 1 (ii).

Also note that, as a rule, whenever you find has/have/had, **been** is always used, but where you find is, was, are, were or am, **being** is used.

Model Question 36

A wide range of options made available to the political parties during the recently conducted elections. (a) was (b) are (c) is (d) were

Clue to answer: The subject of the sentence is **a wide range**, which is singular. Use rule 1(i).

Model Question 37

The government whichrecruiting workers suddenly stopped doing so. (a) are/its (b) were/their (c) is/their (d) was/its

Clue to answer: Take note of the use of **which**, referring to government since **which** cannot apply to people. The question indirectly tells you that government, here, does not mean the **people**, (which is plural) but a **structure** or **entity** (which is singular). **Notional Concord** will help you.

Model Question 38

Neither Agbo nor his parents the meetings now. (a) attended (b) attends (c) has attended (d) attend

Clue to answer: Use **Either / Neither**. Basically, you are also compelled to use the **principle of proximity** (rule 5), which operates the same rule as **either or neither**.

Model Question 39

Three quarters of the hostel been painted and three quarters of the students (a) has / have (b) has / has (c) have / have (d) have / has arrived

Clue to answer: This is **Mathematical Concord** and **Notional Concord** combined. Read rules 7 and 17. Note that three quarters space is **uncountable**, hence **singular**, while three quarters (75%) of students is **plural**. Your answer should be **singular / plural** verbs.

Model Question 40

The highly appreciative audience clapped hands and showered on the lecturer. (a) its / encomium (b) its / invectives (c) their / encomiums (d) their / invectives

Clue to answer: Apply the **Collective Noun Concord** (Notional Concord). Remember, **audience** is a **collective noun** for people who perform action: Use rule 7.

Model Question 41

The quality of your questions which always attracted attention never been in doubt. (a) has / have (b) have / have (c) has / has (d) have / has

Clue to answer: Use rule 12: **Relative Concord**. **Which**, here, refers to **your questions** which is plural and as such, should attract a plural verb in the first gap and **quality** (singular) will attract a singular verb in the second gap.

Model Question 42

The operations of the bank not cottage and small scale industries. (a) do / cover (b) did / covered (c) does / cover (d) does / covered

Clue to answer: The subject is **operations** (plural) requiring a plural verb (without **s**) at the first gap. Remember, you **cannot** have a past tense verb, but a **present tense verb**, AFTER **do, do not, does, does not, did, did not**.

Model Question 43

It is often that inflation from too much money chasing very few goods. (a) say / resulted (b) said / result (c) said / result (d) say / result

Clue to answer: **Inflation** is singular, so, the second gap should have a singular verb.

Model Question 44

Four weeks enough for the police to conclude their investigation. (a) has been (b) are (c) were (d) is

Clue to answer: This is **Mathematical Concord**. Read rule 17. Look at these structures:

Three children is enough for a couple these days (correct).

Fifteen years is long enough to end a quarrel (correct).

THE DEFINITE ARTICLE

Some nouns necessarily have the definite article **the** before them. They include the following categories:

1. **The United Nations, The United States, The United Kingdom and The USSR** will attract singular verbs after them, e.g. **The United States** is (not 'are') rich or **The United Nations** works hard.
2. **Newspapers and Magazines**, e.g. *The Guardian, The Daily Times*. Do not say: I want to buy **Guardian** but, I want to buy **The Guardian**.
3. **Organizations**, e.g. **The Carnegie Foundation**.
4. **Plural proper nouns**, e.g. **The Netherlands, The Midlands, The Himalayas, The Alps, The Rockies**.
5. **Names of families**, e.g. **The Ashades, The Fadamitans, The Aribidos**.
6. **Geographical names**, e.g.
Canals – **The Suez**.
Seas – **The Pacific, The Mediterranean, The Atlantic Ocean**.
Rivers – **The Niger, The Benue, The Euphrates**.
7. **Public Places**, e.g. hotels, restaurants, art theatres, cinemas, museums, libraries etc. **The Chicken George, The K S Motel, The Scala Cinema, The Sheraton, The BCOS, The Voice of Nigeria, The UAC**.
8. **Tribes marked by language** e.g.
The Yoruba, The English, The French, The Sudanese, The Awori etc.

9. **Titles**, e.g. Governor, President, Vice-Chancellor, Auditor – General, Chief-of-Army Staff, Ooni of Ife must have **the** before them, e.g.
The Governor (of Oyo) is here.
The Ooni (of Ife) is known world-wide.
The President knows us as trouble-shooters.
10. Of any two (or more) people or things, the one known better has **the** before the name, e.g.
I spoke to one Wole of Lagos City Hall and not to **the** Wole of the Nobel Laureate fame.

Model Question 1

Bilaminu sent the expensive present to one Miss Sanda of the United African Organization and not to of the Central Bank of Nigeria. (a) the Miss Sanda (b) Miss Sanda (c) a Miss Sanda (d) one Miss Sanda

Clue to answer: Read rule 10 under this topic.

Model Question 2

We left USA and crossed Atlantic Ocean to Europe. (a) the / the/- (b) -/-/- (c) -/-/the (d) the /-/a

Clue to answer: Read rules 1 and 6.

Model Question 3

Ali plays game with remarkable skill. (a) their (b) same (c) a (d) the

Clue to answer: Use rule 2.

GENDER

Gender refers to whether somebody or something is male, female or neuter. The pronoun shows the gender in the following:

- (a) Masculine (He)
- (b) Feminine (She)
- (c) Neuter (It)

He is used when the referent is male or considered very strong. **She** is used not only in reference to female persons but also to things, which the owner holds very dear to himself or herself. A soldier is (because of the love soldiers normally have for their nations) likely to refer to his/her country as **she**. A business is also referred to as a woman, hence, the use of **she**.

The Neuter **It** is used if the sex is not immediately known. If for example you want to know whether a new born baby is a boy or a girl, what do you say; how do you ask? You will say: What is **it**? (Not: Is he a boy or is she a girl?) **She** is also used when sports and the economy of a country are being discussed.

REFLEXIVE PRONOUN

By the suffix **selves or self**, a reflexive pronoun is known, e.g.

1. For **more than one person** including you, use **ourselves**.
2. For **2nd person singular and 2nd person plural**, use **yourself** and **yourselves** respectively.
3. For an unspecified individual, use **himself/herself**.
4. For a non-living thing, use **itself**.
5. For more than one person excluding you, use **themselves**.
6. For one, use **oneself**.

For example:

One has to address strictly to the task ahead.
(a) himself (b) herself (c) oneself (d) themselves

Answer = C.

7. Caution: No reflexive pronoun can be the subject of a clause, e.g. **Myself** saw him (wrong), **I, myself**, saw him (correct)

Mr Jones and **myself** are friends. (wrong) **Mr Hogan** and **I myself**. (correct)

8. One person in relation to another is **each other**. The word **themselves** means that **each person loves himself**. There is nothing as **theirself / theirselves** in the English Language.

Note: Wherever **each other** is correct, **one another** is also correct because they both mean the same thing.

Model Question 1

Asmau, did you see the snapshot of? (a) yourself (b) you (c) yours (d) yourselves

Clue to answer: Read rule 6. Snapshot means photograph.

Model Question 2

Dan and Tina met on the ship and greeted (a) one another. (b) themselves. (c) each other. (d) themselves.

Clue to answer: Read rule 8.

Model Question 3

Did the boys enjoy when they went on vacation?
(a) each other (b) one another (c) themselves (d) themselves

Clue to answer: If **each boy** enjoyed **himself** then, (all) the boys enjoyed **themselves**. Read rule 8. This means that each person took advantage for himself; not one, for another: John enjoyed himself. Solomon enjoyed himself, too. So, both boys enjoyed **themselves**.

Model Question 4

If one perseveres, will surely succeed.

(a) she (b) they (c) one (d) he

Clue to answer: Use rule 7: **one** attracts **one**; **he** attracts **he**, **it** attracts **it**, and so on.

Model Question 5

My classmateI haven't seen for years wrote to me last week.
(a) that (b) whose (c) whom (d) which

Clue to answer: Note that this question does not really fall squarely under this topic but has some relevance to it. This is a **relative pronoun** – related question. Note that you can use **who/whom/which, that** as relative pronoun markers. **That** can be used to refer to a person but it is less formal than **whom**.

RECIPROCAL PRONOUN

Rules:

1. This is a pronoun which shows a one-to-one relationship – a relationship based on symbiotism or reciprocity, e.g.

He saw me and I saw him, so we saw **each other**! If the sense of one-to-one relationship is not suggested, do not use each other.

2. **Themselves** means one being particular about oneself where there are a lot of other such people who are particular about themselves as individuals, too.

The **four boys** love **themselves** means, each one loves himself (not that one loves another). There is not yet a word like **themselves** or **themselves** in the English Language.

You cannot have **ourselves** but **ourselves**. **One another** means exactly the same thing as **each other**. They can, therefore, be interchangeably used. There is no difference, at all, between them.

Model Question 1

Dan and Tina met on the ship and greeted (a) one another (b) themselves (c) each other (d) themselves

Clue to answer: This is a one-to-one greeting.

Model Question 2

Did the boys enjoy when they went on vacation?
(a) each other (b) one another (c) themselves (d) themselves

Clue to answer: This is NOT a "one – person – to – one – person" thing. It is a "one – person – to – himself " thing.

USE OF **so**

Rules

1. **So** may, at one time, be a conjunction, linking two clauses and, at another, be an adverb of degree. So, the user of **so** should be careful enough to determine its function in a particular sentence. When **so** is used as a conjunction, the only function it performs is that it links the two clauses as it introduces an adverbial phrase/clause of result, e.g.
It is raining (**so**) I am going home.
Here, **so** links **it is raining** and **I am going home**.
It also introduces the result of the raining i.e. "I am going home." (as a result of the raining)
2. When, however, **so** is used to show the degree to which something happens, it is compulsory in written English that such a clause be followed by a **that** – clause, e.g.
He is **so** nice (wrong). "He is **so** nice" to what extent or degree?
3. When, however, **very** or **too** is used to show degree, the statement **cannot** have an adjoining **that** clause, e.g.
He is **too** troublesome **that** he wounded himself. (wrong)
She was **very** good **that** she praised me. (wrong)
4. Another word that behaves like **so** as a degree adverb is **such** e.g.
She is **such** a girl **that I will not** like to meet. It usually appears as such **a/an**.
5. Where there is no **so/such**, avoid the **that** clause.
6. When you have **so** + adjective + **a/an**, you should NOT use a '**that**' clause with it, e.g.

Abiodun is **so** handsome **a** boy that you will admire. (wrong)
Abiodun is **such a** handsome boy or **such handsome a**
boy that you will admire.

Model Question 1

There were so many children

- (a) **that** she couldn't feed them all.
- (b) **that** she could feed.
- (c) **that** she couldn't feed.
- (d) **more than** she could feed them all.

Clue to answer: Read rule 2.

Model Question 2

The hill behind the town was so steep

- (a) that no man could find a foot-hold on.
- (b) than any man to find a foot-hold on it.
- (c) for no man to find a foot-hold on.
- (d) that no man could find a foot-hold on it.
- (e) for any man to find a foot-hold on.

Clue to answer: Read rule 2.

Model Question 3

This writer analyses the evils of the society (a) so masterly. (b) very masterly. (c) in such a masterly way. (d) in a masterly way. (e) in so masterly a way.

Clue to answer: Read rule 5.

Model Question 4

There was much noise at night that we couldn't sleep.
(a) such a (b) such (c) that (d) very (e) so

Clue to answer: Read rule 2.

Model Question 5

The angry woman shouted and cursed in language
shocking for words. (a) very (b) far (c) so (d) quite (e) too

Clue to answer: Most options above are adverbs of degree. To express "inability" or "negative quality", use **too**, e.g. He is too tall. (**too** shows "negative quality") or, "That man is too good" means, he is bad. "Very", on the other hand, shows a positive or negative quality.

Model Question 6

He was weak he could not climb the stairs.
(a) so/that (b) too/that (c) very/that (d) so/when

Clue to answer: Read rule 2.

Model Question 7

AIDS is disease that kills slowly but surely. (a) too much a deadly (b) very deadly (c) so deadly a (d) such deadly a

Clue to answer: Use rule 6. Remember, "deadly" is an adjective (not an adverb). Some funny adjectives end in **ly**, e.g. a **miserly** man/ a **cowardly** soldier.

Model Question 8

He is so credulous my story about the ghost: (a) to believe (b) that he believes (c) in order to believe (d) since he believes

Clue to answer: Use rule 2.

STATIVE, NON-CONCLUSIVE VERBS

There are some verbs which cannot be written in the **ing** form, as verbs. They are called **stative verbs**. They are also called **non-conclusive verbs**. They include the following:

Rule 1: Category A: Mental state verbs

Agree, differ, disagree, disbelieve, distrust, doubt, find, recognize, recollect, regard, remember, see, suppose, think, trust, understand.

Rule 2: Category B: Emotional state verbs

Abhor, adore, astonish, desire, detest, dislike, displease, feel (that) forgive, hate, mope, like, love, mind (object to) please, prefer, want, wish.

Rule 3: Category C: Miscellaneous

Appear (seem), belong, consist (of), contain, depend, deserve, equal, have, matter, possess, resemble, seem, suffice, keep (when "keep" means "be a part of")

When all these are used as verbs, they cannot be in the **ing** form. You cannot say: "I'm **hearing** you" (wrong) or "I'm **understanding** you." (wrong) or "I'm **seeing** you for the first time." Instead, say, "This is the first time I have seen you." You can, however, use them as gerundive nouns, e.g.

Seeing you here gladdens me.

In this statement, **seeing** is a noun, though, in **ing** form. Other verbs listed here can be treated in the same way.

Model Question 1

You can go on; I what you are saying. (a) am understanding (b) may be understanding (c) was understanding (d) will be understanding (e) understand

Clue to answer: Use rule 1.

Model Question 2

Many streets in the town in need of light at night.
(a) stand (b) stood (c) have stood (d) are standing

Clue to answer: Use rule 3.

Model Question 3

The woman warned her daughter not to with bad boys.
(a) move (b) be moving (c) be keeping company (d) keep company

Clue to answer: Use rule 3.

HOMOPHONES AND SPELLINGS

Homophones are words which sound alike. Because **principal** and **principle**, **piece** and **peace** sound alike, a candidate is likely to use the words wrongly. Given below are the commonest homophones with short notes on them:

1. **ant** – **aunt** (your mother's or father's sister)
2. **ball** – **bale** (of cloth)
3. **bare** (naked) – **bear** (carry)
4. **bell** – **belle** (female)
5. **blew** (past of blow) – **blue** (colour)
6. **boy** – **buoy** (to make active)
7. **buy** – **by, bye**
8. **cease** (stop) – **seize** (hold something down)
9. **check** – **cheque** (banking document)
10. **coarse** (not smooth) – **course, curse** (opposite of bless)
11. **core** (important) – **corps** (pronounced without **ps**)
12. **council** (group of administrators) – **counsel** (adviser/lawyer)
13. **dear** (as in Dear Olu) – **deer** (animal)
14. **desert** (place without plants) – **dessert** (refreshment after meal)
15. **die** – **dye** (chemical for clothes)
16. **draft** – **draught** (game)
17. **ewe** (a young sheep) – **you**

18. **fair - fare** (no thorough fare)
19. **feat** (a surprising achievement) – **feet**
20. **flour** (powdery substance) – **flower** (plant)
21. **fore** (front/before) – **four**
22. **foul** (not fair) – **fowl** (hen)
23. **grate** – **great**: (remember **grate**ful (not **great**ful) meaning thankful)
24. **hail** (greet) – **hale** (healthy)
25. **hair** (of the head) – **hare** (a fast animal)
26. **hear** (listen) – **here** (opposite of there)
27. **heard** (past tense and past participle) of **hear**
28. **herd** (collective for cattle)
29. **him** – **hymn** (church song)
30. **hole** – **whole** (complete)
31. **holy** (without sin) – **wholly** (complete)
32. **hour** (of the clock) – **our**
33. **knew** (past tense of **know**) – **new** (opposite of old)
34. **lightening** (make light) – **lightning** (accompanying thunder)
35. **loan** (money given out) – **lone** (single)
36. **made** (past tense of make) – **maid** (female servant)
37. **mail** (letters) – **male** (opposite of female)
38. **meat** – **meet**

39. **peace** – **piece**
40. **peal** – **peel** (remove the outer skin)
41. **plain** – **plane** (shortened form of 'aeroplane')
42. **practice** (n) – **practise** (vb)
43. **principal** (head/important) – **principle** (policy, ideal)
44. **rains** – **reigns/reins** (or power)
45. **read** – **reed**
46. **real** – **reel**
47. **right** – **rite** (religious ceremony)
48. **root** – **route** (way/path)
49. **sail** (travel by water) – **sale**
50. **scene** – **seen**
51. **sent** (past of send) – **cent** (hundred)
52. **sea** – **see**
53. **seem** (appear/look like) – **seam**
54. **sew** (joining pieces of cloth etc. together) – **so**,
sow (to plant)
55. **sight** (the sense of seeing) – **site** (place of new buildings)
cite (to make/read something)
56. **sole** (one) – **soul**
57. **son** – **sun**
58. **stair** (a flight of stairs) – **stare** (to gaze at)

59. **stationary** (not moving) – **stationery** (writing materials especially paper)
60. **steal** – **steel**
61. **tail** – **tale** (story)
62. **tears** – **tiers** (section/part)
63. **throne** – **thrown** (past participle of **throw**)
64. **tide** (wave of sea) – **tied** (past tense/participle of **tie**)
65. **waist** (middle part of one's body) – **waste** (not used usefully)
66. **wait** – **weight**
67. **we** (referring to us) – **will** (modal auxiliary)
68. **weak** (not strong) – **wick** (lantern thread)
69. **won** (past tense/participle of **win**) – **one**
70. **wood** – **would** (modal auxiliary past of **will**)

SPELLINGS

Here is a list of words that are often mis-spelt. Take note of them.

1. **until** (not: **untill** but **till**)
2. **separate** (not: **seperate/seprate**)
3. **psalm** (not: **sam**)
4. **bouquet** (pronounced: /bukei/)
5. **privilege** (not **priviledge**)
6. **ceiling**
7. **receive** (not: **recieve**)

8. **receipt** (not: reciept)
9. **niece** (not: neice)
10. **dying** (continuous form of (die))
11. **Wednesday** (pronounced: /**wensday** /wensdei/)
12. **dyeing** (continuous form of dye)
13. **deceive** (not: decieve)
14. **sergeant**
15. **rendezvous** (pronounced: / rondivuu /)
16. **connoisseur**
17. **etiquette**
18. **guitar**
19. **apostle** (pronounced: /æ'pɒsul/)
20. **seize** (not: sieze) **changeable** (not: changable)
21. **relieve** (not: releive)
22. **fashion** (not: fashon)
23. **millennium** (10^3 years)
24. **occasion** (c²)
25. **personnel** (n²)
26. **quite**
27. **quiet** (silent)
28. **curious**
29. **February** (not: Febuary)
30. **bicycle**
31. **diarrhoea**
32. **diary** (notebook)
33. **dairy** (relating to animal husbandry)

34. **chauffeur** (f²)
35. **lieutenant** (pronounced / leftenant/)
36. **rhythm**
37. **believe** (not: beleive) **believable**
38. **pneumonia** (not: nemonia)
39. **catarrh** (not: catagh)
40. **potatoes** (not: potatos)
41. **manifestoes** (not: manifestos)
42. **noticeable** (not: noticable)
43. **movable** (not: moveable)
44. **equip** (ped)
45. **marriageable**
46. **accommodation** (c²m²)
47. **preventable**
48. **digestible** (not: digestable)
49. **restaurant**
50. **occurrence**
51. **cause** (be responsible for)
52. **curse** (opposite of 'bless')
53. **embarrass** (ed) (r²s²)
54. **curious**
55. **match** (football playing)
56. **coarse** (not: smooth)
57. **occur** (ence) (c²)
58. **course** (pattern of / career study, time of)
59. **seize** (confiscate)
60. **cease** (stop)

61. **incessant** (s²) (continuous)
62. **guide lines** (not: guidelines)
63. **acquire**
64. **asthma**
65. **bouquet**
66. **pronounce**; **pronunciation** (not: pron**oun**ciation)
67. **manoeuvre**
68. **amateur**
69. **teetotaler**
70. **mischievous** (not: mischiv**ious**)
71. **rheumatism** (not: rheumantism)

Model Question 1

They our donation with thanks. (a) recieved (b) recived (c) received (d) receved (e) receipt

Clue to answer: Use rule 7 (spelling).

Model Question 2

On such an important all the guests were expected to be at their best. (a) occassion (b) occasion (c) ocassion (d) ocasion (e) occason

Clue to answer: Use rule 24 (spelling).

Model Question 3

I have applied foron the campus and it is almost certain I shall get it. (a) acommodation (b) accommondation (c) accomodation (d) acomodation (e) accommodation

Clue to answer: Use rule 46.

Model Question 4

Select the wrongly spelt: (a) disappointed (b) embarassed
(c) equipped (d) rhythm (e) restaurant

Clue to answer: Use rule 53.

Model Question 5

Select the wrongly spelt: (a) occurence (b) surprise (c) personnel
(d) possess (e) curiously

Clue to answer: Use rule 50.

Model Question 6

Select the wrongly spelt: (a) quiet (b) beleive (c) proceed (d) precede
(e) opportunity

Clue to answer: Use rule 37.

Model Question 7

I was seriously disappointed when the between the two teams
ended in a goalless draw. (a) march (b) marsh (c) match (d) mash
(e) martch

Clue to answer: Use rule 55.

Model Question 8

The politicians are responsible for the events have taken
in this country. (a) course (b) curse (c) coarse (d) cause
(e) corse

Clue to answer: Use rule 58.

Model Question 9

That single was enough to spoil a whole lifetime of good living. (a) occurrence (b) ocurence (c) occurrence (d) occurence (e) ocurrence

Clue to answer: Use rule 50.

Model Question 10

The officer was compelled to the suspects car. (a) seize (b) cease (c) sieze (d) sease

Clue to answer: Use rule 59.

Model Question 11

Many unrelated issues were touched upon in the of the discussion. (a) cause (b) course (c) coarse (d) curse

Clue to answer: Use rule 58.

Model Question 12

The government has provided new for the local government polls. (a) guard lines (b) guide lines (c) guardlines (d) guidelines

Clue to answer: Use rule 62.

Model Question 13

The Pastor said, lay your hearts to God. (a) bier (b) bear (c) bare (d) bar

Clue to answer: Read rule 4: **Homophones.**

Model Question 14

Ebun Ojointernational fame as an actress. (a) aquired
(b) acquired (c) acquiared (d) acquired

Clue to answer: Use rule 63.

Model Question 15

The story of the lost jewel was quite (a) unbelievable
(b) unbeleveable (c) unbeleveable (d) unblieviable

Clue to answer: Use rule 37.

Model Question 16

The patient is suffering from (a) reumatism (b)
rheumantism (c) rheumatism (d) rhematism

Clue to answer: Use rule 71.

Model Question 17

The attitude of my students to baffles me.
(a) pronounciation (b) pronunciation (c) pronuceation
(d) pronounceation

Clue to answer: Use rule 66.

Model Question 18

The army officer said that more would be needed to
prosecute the war. (a) geurrillas (b) guerillas (c) geurrillas (d) guerrillas

Clue to answer: Note g + u + e + r²

Model Questions 19

I have the of meeting the president. (a) privilege (b) priviledge
(c) privelege (d) previlege

Clue to answer: Use rule 5.

TENSES

Tense refers to the relationship between an action and the time of its execution. If something happened yesterday, the verb to be used will be quite different from the one to be used for action that will take place tomorrow. Here, we shall examine thoroughly some tenses and rules relating to the relationship between an action and the time it is done.

We have the following tenses:

- (a) **Present tense** – e.g. go, is, am, has/have
- (b) **Past tense** – e.g. went, was, were, had
- (c) **Past participle** – This can take various forms:
 - **en**,. e.g. beat, beat, beaten
 - **ed**, e.g. walk, walked, walked
 - unchanged, e.g. **hit**, hit, **hit**
 - changed, e.g. **seek**, sought, **sought**
 - present and past participle, the same, e.g. **come** / came/ **come**

Verbs that take **ed** at the past and past-participle levels are called **regular verbs**. Those that take other forms are called **irregular verbs**. There is a long list of such verbs laid out as follows:

Infinitive	Past Tense	Past Participle
Abide	abode, abided	abode, abided
Arise	arose	arisen
Awake	awoke	awoken
Be	was/were	been
Bear	bore	bome
Beat	beat	beaten

Become	became	become
Befall	befell	befallen
Beget	begot	begotten
Begin	began	begun
Behold	beheld	beheld
Bend	bent	bent
Beseech	besought	besought
Beset	beset	beset
Bet	bet	bet
Bid	bid, *bade	bidden, *bid
Bind	bound	bound
Bite	bit	bitten
Bleed	bled	bled
Bless	blessed	blessed
Blow	blew	blown
Break	broke	broken
Breed	bred	bred
Bring	brought	brought
Broadcast	broadcast	broadcast
Browbeat	browbeat	browbeaten
Build	built	built
Burn	burnt, burned	burnt, burned
Burst	burst	burst
Bust	bust, busted	bust, busted
Buy	bought	bought
Cast	cast	cast
Catch	caught	caught

Chide	chided	chided
Choose	chose	chosen
Cleave	cleaved, clove, cleft	cleaved, cloven, cleft
Cleave ²	clave	cleaved
Mishear	misheard	misheard
Mishit	mishit	mishit
Mislay	mislaid	mislaid
Misread/misri:d	misread	misread
Misspell	misspelled/mispelt	misspelled/mispelt
Misspend	misspent	misspent
Mistake	mistook	misunderstood
Mow	mowed	mown
Offset	offset	offset
Outbid	outbid	outbid
Outdo	outdid	outdid
Outfight	outfought	outfought
Outgrow	outgrew	outgrown
Output	output	output
Outrun	outrun	outrun
Outsell	outsold	outsold
Outshine	outshone	outshone
Overcome	overcame	overcome
Overdo	overdid	overdone
Overdraw	overdrew	overdrawn
Overeat	overate	overeaten
Overfly	overflew	overflown
Overhang	overhung	overhung

Overhear	overheard	overheard
Overlay	overlaid	overlaid
Overpay	overpaid	overpaid
Override	overrode	overridden
Overrun	overran	overrun
Oversee	oversaw	overseen
Overshoot	overshot	overshot
Oversleep	overslept	overslept
Overspend	overspent	overspent
Overtake	overtook	overtaken
Overthrow	overthrew	overthrown
Overwrite	overwrote	overwritten
Partake	partook	partaken
Pay	paid	paid
Plead	pleaded; pled	pleaded; pled
Proofread	proofread	proofread
Prove	proved	proven
Put	put	put
Quit	quit	quit
Read	read	read
Rebuild	rebuild	rebuilt
Recast	recast	recast
Redo	redid	redone
Rehear	reheard	reheard
Remake	remade	remade
Rend	rent	rent
Repay	repaid	repaid

Rerun	reran	rerun
Resell	resold	resold
Reset	reset	reset
Resit	resat	resat
Retake	retook	retaken
Retell	retold	retold
Rewind	rewound	rewound
Rewrite	rewrote	rewritten
Rid	rid	rid
Ride	rode	ridden
Ring	rang	rung
Rise	rose	risen
Run	ran	run
Saw	sawed	sawn
Say	said	said
See	saw	seen
Seek	sought	sought
Sell	sold	sold
Send	sent	sent
Set	set	set
Shake	shook	shaken
Shear	sheared	shorn, sheared
Shed	shed	shed
Shine	shone, *shined	shone, *shined
Shit	shitted, shat	shitted, shat
Shoot	shot	shot
Show	showed.	shown, showed

Shrink	shrank, shrunk	shrunk
Shut	shut	shut
Sing	sang	sung
Sink	sank	sunk
Sit	sat	sat
Slay	slew	slain
Sleep	slept	slept
Slide	slid	slid
Sling	slung	slung
Slink	slunk	slunk
Slit	slit	slit
Smell	smelt, smelled	smelt, smelled
Smite	smote	smitten
Sow	sowed	sown, sowed
Speak	spoke	spoken
Speed	sped, speeded	sped, speeded
Spell	spelt, spelled	spelt, spelled
Spend	spent	spent
Spill	spilt, spilled	split, spilled
Spin	spun, span	spun
Spit	spat, spit	spat, spit
Spilt	spilt	spilt
Spoil	spoilt, spoiled	spoilt, spoiled
Spotlight	spotlighted	spotlighted
Spread	spread	spread
Spring	sprang	sprung
Stand	stood	stood

Stave	staved, *stove	staved, *stove
Steal	stolen	stolen
Stick	stuck	stuck
Sting	stung	stung
Stink	stank, stunk	stank, stunk
Strew	strewed	strewed, strewn
Stride	strode	
Strive	strove	striven
Sublet	sublet	sublet
Swear	swore	sworn
Sweep	swept	swept
Swell	swelled	swollen, swelled
Swim	swam	swum
Swing	swung	swung
Take	took	taken
Teach	taught	taught
Tear	tore	torn
Tell	told	told
Think	thought	thought
Throw	threw	thrown
Thrust	thrust	thrust
Tread	trod	trodden, trod
Typecast	typecast	typecast
Underbend	underbent	underbent
Underbid	underbid	underbid
Undercut	undercut	undercut
Undergo	underwent	undergone

Underlie	underlay	underlain
Underpay	underpaid	underpaid
Undersell	undersold	undersold
Understand	understood	understood
Undertake	undertook	undertaken
Underwrite	underwrote	underwritten
Undo	undid	undone
Unfreeze	unfroze	unfrozen
Unwind	unwound	unwound
Unhold	unheld	unheld
Upset	upset	upset
Wake	woke	woken
Waylay	waylaid	waylaid
Wear	wore	worn
Weave	wove, *weaved	woven, *weaved
Wed	wedded, wed	wedded, wed
Weep	wept	wept
Wet	wet, wetted	wet, wetted
Win	won	won
Wind	wound	wound
Withdraw	withdrew	withdrawn
Withhold	withheld	withheld
Withstand	withstood	withstood
Wring	wrung	wrung
Write	wrote	written

- (d) **Future Tense:** This is the tense carrying modal auxiliaries and lexical verbs.

Will and **shall** are the modal auxiliaries used explicitly for indicating future actions.

Only **I** and **We** can however be used with **shall**, while **he, she, it, you** and **they** cannot.

This table illustrates it:

Personal Pronoun	Will	Shall
I	✓	✓
we	✓	✓
he	✓	X
she	✓	X
it	✓	X
you	✓	X
they	✓	X

So, it is wrong to say: "She **shall** go tomorrow" when we wish to indicate what **she** is to do in future. But in commands or orders like those given by law courts; **shall** can be used with all personal pronouns.

"You **shall** appear here tomorrow" means "You must...." or "You are commanded to...." If it is an order, **shall** can be used with any type of personal pronoun. But if indicating what is to be done in future is what we want, **shall** is restricted to only **I** and **We**.

Rules:

1. When **as if** is used, the following verb should be in past form, e.g.
 - a. He walks **as if** he **were** (not: **is**) a king.

- b. She talks **as if** she **knew** everything.
2. **Subject + Primary auxiliary + supposed, e.g.**
- a. John **is** supposed to
not: John supposed to... but
- b. The boys are supposed to
not: The boys supposed to
3. When **has, have** or **had** is used, you should **not** indicate any **definite time** when the action was performed, e.g.
He went yesterday. (correct)
He **has** gone **yesterday**. (wrong)
But, if you wish to use any of **has/have/had** with the time of action you must put **for** or **since** before the time indicated, e.g.
He has gone **since + five o'clock**. (time)
He has gone **for + three hours**. (time)
4. When **has/have/had** is used, the verb that follows it must be a **past participle** one, e.g.
He has **eaten**, not: He has **ate**.
We have **written** our notes, not: We have **write** or, We **have wrote** (wrong)
5. When **mind, minded, help, like, being kept** etc are used, the next verb should be **ing**, e.g.
Do you mind/would you mind + ing
- I couldn't **help** laugh-**ing** yesterday, not:
 - I couldn't **help to laugh** yesterday.
 - We do not **mind singing**, not:
 - We do not **mind to sing**.

6. **Wish + Subject + Past tense verb, etc.** For example:

I wish I **knew** you.

I wish I **were** you.

7. **Subject + happened/seem/appeared + to have + past participle**

She happened to have died.

They happened to have offended me.

I should not have appeased the traffic policeman, but

I **happened + to have + flouted** some traffic regulations.

8. **//If he had run away//, //he would not have died//**

Look at the two strokes bordering from, **if** to **away** and from **he** to **died** (// //). Those strokes stand for a clause, so, there are two clauses in the formula above. In examination, you may be given one of the clauses and for the second part, a gap to fill in. You will just use the formula appropriate, e.g.

//She would have answered it//

- (a) if the telephone rang.
- (b) if the telephone was ringing.
- (c) should the telephone ring.
- (d) if the telephone had rung.

Answer is D.

You have been given clause 2. So, use the formula for clause 1 to get the answer. You will see that **D** follows the formula given above. If + subject + had + pp verb, **if the telephone had rung** can also be written as **Had the telephone rung**

9. **// Subject + past tense // + // Subject + past tense //**
 This shows that if the tense in clause one is in the present, the verb in the second will be in the present, too. The same goes for past tense. This is 'tense balancing' in a clause, e.g.

//He **called** us // and // we **answered** him.// (past + past)

10.

// "By" / "when"	+ future time	+ subject	+ would/will/ shall	+ have + pp vb//
By	next June	I	shall	have read 10 books
By	December,	he	will	have read ten books
When	+it is night fall	she	will	have slept for five hours

Remember, you cannot say: **she shall** or **he shall**: but **I shall** or **we shall**.

11. After **it's time** or **it is high time** + subject, a past tense verb follows:

It is time/It is hightime + subject + past tense + ...

- it is time	Joan	went home
- it is hightime	Murphy	came back

But if **says** or **said** appears, it will determine whether you would have "it **is** time" or "it **was** time", "it **is** hightime" or "it **was** hightime" e.g. He **said** (past) it **was** time/hightime he left.

He **says** (present) it **is** time/hightime he left.

12. // + Subject + present tense// + //subject + present tense

If you travel you will learn.

but

// "if" + subject + past tense// +// subject+ past tense+ .//

If you travelled you would learn.

13. Subject + /prm. aux +

feared/

believed

/thought/

reported

imagined

said +

+ to have + pp. verb

The journalist was said to have died.

Try this: We..... believed (a) are/to died. (b) were/to died. (c) are/to have died. (d) were/to have died.

Answer is D.

14. Subject + would rather + subject + Past Tense

I would rather you came tomorrow.
('d rather)

We would rather you left the room.
('d rather)

15. Subject + would rather + present tense

I would rather come tomorrow.
('d rather)

We would rather leave the room.
(**'d rather**)

Please take note of the difference between 14 and 15.

16. **Subject** + **had better** + **present tense**
You **had better** **leave** now.

NOT:

You **better** **leave** now.

17. Before you use **had**, these are the conditions: (a) there must be two clauses (b) there should be one of the following time adverbs: **until, before, after, when, hardly had..... when, No sooner had..... than**, e.g.

He **had** gone (clause 1) **before** I came (clause 2).

The two clauses can now be joined together. You cannot use **has** in this way, e.g.

He had gone **before** I came.

18. Any verb that follows **to** should be in present tense without **s**, even if the event you are describing is in past tense – just put a present tense verb after **to**, e.g.

I wanted **to** + **go** last year.

She likes **to** + **see** you.

We need **to** + **know** him.

There are certain exceptions to this rule where you find an **ing** coming after **to**. Some of them are:

- i. With a **view to finding**.
- ii. **I look forward to seeing**.
- iii. She is **used to dancing**.

- iv. We are **limited to** talking only to the guests.
- v. He **object(ed) to** killing the man.
- vi. They **are devoted to** helping their friends.
- vii. She **admitted to** stealing my money.
- viii. He **confessed to** committing the crime.
- ix. I **am not disposed to** waking up early.
- x. They **are accustomed to** writing long sentences.
- xi. We can **swear to** being good boys.
- xii. She **prefers** singing to dancing.
- xiii. You **feel up to** running now, don't you?

Apart from these, any verb that follows **to** should be in present tense without **s**.

MODEL QUESTIONS

Model Question 1

I would not have condescended to appease the traffic policeman but I happened some traffic regulations. (a) to have broken (b) to be breaking (c) to break (d) to break in (e) to have evaded

Clue to answer: Use rule 7.

Model Question 2

If this had happened to you, what? (a) would you do (b) have you done (c) would you have done (d) will you do (e) would you doing

Clue to answer: Use rule 8.

Model Question 3

What a relief that the strike..... when it did. (a) would end (b) was ending (c) ended (d) has ended (e) is ending

Clue to answer: Because of "did", your answer must be in past tense (to fill the gap). Read rule 9: **Tense balancing**.

Model Question 4

Isn't it hightime you.....your office? (a) are leaving (b) do leave (c) leave (d) left (e) did leave

Clue to answer: Use rule 11.

Model Question 5

By the end of this year in this town for eleven years.
(a) I'm living (b) I'd be living (c) I'll live (d) I'll have lived (e) I have lived

Clue to answer: Use rule 10.

Model Question 6

If he had left home earlier, he late. (a) would not be late (b) would have not been (c) would not been (d) would have been not (e) would not have been

Clue to answer: Use rule 8.

Model Question 7

I saw you walking in that direction but I did not know exactly
(a) where are you going. (b) where you were going. (c) where were you going to. (d) to where were you going. (e) where you are going.

Clue to answer: I "saw". "Saw" shows past action. You must balance the other clause with a past tense verb. Use rule 9.

Model Question 8

Do you know if the new teacher yet? (a) is arrived (b) will be arriving (c) has arrived (d) had arrived (e) has been arriving

Clue to answer: "new teacher" is singular subject. Note also the difference between the use of **has** and **had**. Read rule 17.

Model Question 9

It is time we (a) should be going. (b) ought to go. (c) are going. (d) went. (e) go.

Clue to answer: Use rule 11.

Model Question 10

By the end of next semester he..... his University education. (a) would have completed (b) will be completing (c) shall have completed (d) was completing (e) must complete

Clue to answer: Use rule 10.

Model Question 11

In the past his father used to walk but nowadays, he to work by bicycle. (a) was going (b) is going (c) seldomly goes (d) goes (e) has gone

Clue to answer: Take "nowadays" into consideration. It is better to say, for example: "I **go** to school nowadays". So, from here, find your answer.

Model Question 12

He acts he were a general manager. (a) as (b) if (c) as if (d) so as (e) that

Clue to answer: Use rule 1.

Model Question 13

Shall we go to the Union meeting? No, thank you, I do not feel like ... anywhere. (a) go (b) going (c) to go (d) to have gone (e) went

Clue to answer: Use rule 5.

Model Question 14

I started writing this test at 8:00am. It is 10:00am now. By 11:00am, I it for three hours. (a) shall be writing (b) have been writing (c) shall have been writing (d) am writing (e) was writing

Clue to answer: Use rule 10.

Model Question 15

If I were the Head of the English Department in my school, I make Oral English a compulsory subject. (a) would (b) could (c) should (d) might (e) had

Clue to answer: Use rule 12.

Model Question 16

He bought a typewriter with a view to type. (a) to learning (b) to learnt (c) to be learning (d) to be learnt (e) to have learnt

Clue to answer: Read rule 18 (i).

Model Question 17

It is time we this irresponsible member. (a) expel (b) are to expel (c) will expel (d) are expelling (e) expelled

Clue to answer: Use rule 11.

Model Question 18

Had he known in advance, he (a) should prepare for the interview. (b) was going to prepare for the interview. (c) would have prepared for the interview. (d) will have been preparing for the interview. (e) may be preparing for the interview.

Clue to answer: Use rule 8.

Model Question 19

He was reported the policeman. (a) to be assaulting (b) to assault (c) assaulting (d) to have assaulted (e) to have been assaulted

Clue to answer: Use rule 13.

Model Question 20

When John reported the incident, the teacher remarked that he a responsible boy. (a) was (b) is (c) will be (d) should have been (e) is being

Clue to answer: "reported" in the question shows past time (tense), so the second part of the sentence should also be past. Use rule 9.

Model Question 21

If one day, we would talk about it for weeks. (a) a lion would be coming into this room (b) a lion was coming into this room (c) a lion came into this room (d) a lion is coming into this room (e) a lion is going to come into this room

Clue to answer: In the second part of this question ... **would talk...** which is past, shows that the event reported in clause 1 did NOT happen (*unreal condition*). For unreal conditions, past tense verbs are used for each of the two clauses making up the statement of the question.

Model Question 22

A policeman stopped me and I to the police stations.
(a) was taken (b) took (c) am taken (d) will be taken (e) walk

Clue to answer: Use rule 9.

Model Question 23

He devoted himself homeless children. (a) to helping (b) to help (c) by helping (d) with helping (e) helping

Clue to answer: Use rule 18(vi).

Model Question 24

By the end of June, I six examinations this year. (a) shall take (b) have taken (c) shall have taken (d) am taking (e) took

Clue to answer: Use rule 10 and **Future Tense**, under **Tenses** in this book. Study the match of personal pronouns with **will** and **shall**.

Model Question 25

The guests breakfast by the time the bus arrives. (a) are finishing (b) have finished (c) shall have finished (d) had finished (e) will have finished

Clue to answer: Read **Future Tense** under **Tenses** in this book. Also under **Tenses**, read rule 19.

Model Question 26

Do come tonight but don't expect me to speak to you because I an interesting programme on television when you arrive.
(a) am watching (b) watch (c) watched (d) shall be watching (e) have watched

Clue to answer: Read **Future Tense** under **Tenses** in this book.

Model Question 27

F: Can I clean this old engine in the sitting room?

T: I would rather it in the garage.

(a) you cleaned (b) you are cleaning (c) you clean (d) you will clean
(e) didn't clean

Clue to answer: Read and use rule 14.

Model Question 28

The dead body of the armed robber has..... in the street for three days. (a) laid (b) lain (c) layed (d) lied (e) lay

Clue to answer: After / has / have / had, the next verb should be past participle. Learn the table of tenses laid on some previous pages.

Model Question 29

Do you mind another minute or two? (a) to wait (b) wait (c) waiting (d) having waited (e) being awaited.

Clue to answer: Read and use rule 5.

Model Question 30

A: Do you mind if I wait for the reply?

B: I'd rather you again tomorrow. (a) called (b) will call (c) can call (d) call (e) were calling.

Clue to answer: Read and use rule 14.

Model Question 31

It was a funny episode, so I (a) can't help to laugh (b) couldn't help laugh (c) couldn't help laughing (d) couldn't help to laugh
(e) can't help laughing

Clue to answer: Read and use rule 5.

Model Question 32

It all depended on what (a) does he want (b) he wants
(c) he does want (d) he wanted (e) did he want

Clue to answer: Use rule 9. Remember you have to balance the tenses in the two clauses. Consider **depended**.

Model Question 33

A number of doctors are not so well disposed to..... in government hospitals these days, are they? (a) working / do
(b) work/are (c) working/are (d) work/aren't

Clue to answer: Use rule 18 (ix).

Model Question 34

Wada said that two of his chickens eggs yesterday morning.
(a) layed (b) lied (c) laid (d) lain

Clue to answer: Use the past tense of "lay" (of egg).

Model Question 35

Ore so if she thought it necessary. (a) would have said (b) would say
(c) may have said (d) could say

Clue to answer: Use rule 8.

Model Question 36

Are you sure he prefers a horse ride a walk. (a) than to take
(b) to taking (c) instead to take (d) than

Clue to answer: Use rule 18(xiii).

Model Question 37

The whole class looked forward to Kainji Dam at Christmas.
(a) visiting (b) visit (c) be visiting (d) a visit

Clue to answer: Use rule 18 (ii).

Model Question 38

If Kaka hadn't tried to stand up in the boat, he into the lake
(a) wouldn't have fallen (b) will not have fall (c) will not have fallen (d) would not have fall

Clue to answer: Use rule 8.

Model Question 39

If I had not finished my assignment, I would not the opportunity to go with the group. (a) have been given (b) be given (c) be giving (d) have been giving

Clue to answer: Use rule 8.

Model Question 40

You had better what the doctor recommended this morning.
(a) done (b) do (c) did (d) be doing

Model Question 41

The buildings damaged by the rainstorm schools, hospitals and private houses. (a) included (b) include (c) were included (d) was including

Clue to answer: Use "tense balancing". "damaged" is past tense.

Model Question 42

A number of teachers in secondary schools are not so well disposed to these days, they? (a) teach/aren't (b) teaching/are (c) teach/do (d) teach/are

Clue to answer: Use rule 18 (ix).

Model Question 43

She asked me whether I the letter for her. (a) minded to post (b) mind to post (c) minded posting (d) minded to posting

Clue to answer: Use rule 5.

Model Question 44

How I wish I my mother's advice. (a) had heeded (b) have heeded (c) heed (d) will heed

Clue to answer: Use rule 6.

Model Question 45

Before mechanization, farmers water out of fabrics with their hands. (a) wring (b) wrung (c) wrang (d) wringed

Clue to answer: What is the past tense of wring?

Model Question 46

..... him around, I would have informed you. (a) Had I seen (b) Have I seen (c) Should I see (d) If I saw

Clue to answer: Use rule 8.

Model Question 47

Do you prefer my rickety car? (a) going on foot to taking (b) to go on foot to taking (c) going on foot than taking (d) to go on foot than to take

Clue to answer: Use rule 18 (xii).

Model Question 48

The keepers themselves are sometimes by the bees. (a) stinged (b) stang (c) stung (d) sting

Clue to answer: You are to use the past participle verb form of sting.

Model Question 49

The old man couldn't help at his grandson's babbling. (a) to laugh (b) that he laughed (c) laughing (d) in lughing

Clue to answer: Use rule 5.

Model Question 50

What saved her was that she to the side of the roof. (a) had clinged (b) clung (c) clinged (d) clang

Clue to answer: What is the past form of cling?

Model Question 51

Her mother said to her, I the dinner now. (a) would rather you cooked (b) would rather you cook (c) would rather you not cook (d) would rather you have cooked

Clue to answer: Use rule 15.

Model Question 52

By January 1999, I ten years in the service of this institution. (a) should have (b) would be (c) can be (d) must be

Clue to answer: Use rule 10.

APOSTROPHE (')

Apostrophe – as a mechanical device in English – is a comma-like sign put on a word to show certain things. At times, that sign may show **possession**. At another time, it may show **omission** or **contraction** or it can even help to **pluralise** items – words and numbers.

Functions of Apostrophe

1. **Possession Function:** Some people simply choose to put apostrophe anywhere they find s. No. One of the conditions for using the apostrophe is that you are sure that someone **possesses** something.

(a) **Singular Possession:** This is when only one person/thing possesses something, e.g. Ade, The boy, My friend each is singular and should have an apostrophe on the name – where the name of that person ends – and an 's', before what that person possesses would appear in front. For example:

- i. Ade's bag
- ii. The boy's bag
- iii. My friend's pen

Note that the apostrophe comes after the name of the owner.

(b) **Plural Possessor:** This is when more than one person/thing possesses something, e.g. **The boys, my friends**. So, to show possession, put an apostrophe in front of the **boys, my friends**, thus:

The boys' bag. Note that the apostrophe comes *after* the name of the owners.

(c) **Possessors ending in s**, e.g. Ladies, Princess.

Note that, here, there will be an apostrophe after **ladies**, **princess**, without an additional **s** thus: Ladies' bags, the Princess' legs.

(d) **Possessor in irregular plural form**: Possessor in irregular plural forms, **children**, **women**, **men**, are irregular plurals, whereas boy + s = boys; table + s = tables are regular plurals. We cannot have woman + s = "womans" plural. So, these irregular nouns will take an apostrophe after them. For example:

- i. One child's bag.
- ii. Two children's bags.
- iii. One man's meat.
- iv. Three men's meat.

(e) **Family Possessor**: When a family possesses something, **the** must come before the name of the family and an **s** added to that name, plus apostrophe after the **s**, e.g.

'The family of Ashade has a Limousine' can be written thus:
The Ashades' Limousine.

(f) **Joint Possession**: When two or more people possess one thing, the names of the two or three or even ten will be written but it is the last name that will carry an apostrophe, plus **s**. For example:

May and Baker's company.

(g) **Possessor of Possessor**: When someone possesses something and that thing possesses something, both possessors must carry apostrophe.

Mr John has a son. The son has a pencil. This can be written thus:

Mr John's son's pencil.

- (h) **Greek, Biblical and Roman Names in Possession:** Greek names usually end in **s**, e.g. Socrates, Euripides, Aristophanes, etc. No additional **s** will be given but there will be an apostrophe after the name:
- Socrates' philosophy.
 - Euripides' plays.
- (i) **English names as possessors:** English names such as James, Francis, Charles etc, that end in **s** bring confusion. There are two forms:
- There will be additional **s** and an apostrophe before that **s**. **Charles's** bag, or
 - There will **not** be additional **s** but there will be an apostrophe, e.g. Charles' bag, St. James' Cathedral.
- (j) **Apostrophe showing people's homes:**
To say you want to go to Janet's house can be put as:
I am going to Janet's (without house).
- (k) **Time as possessor:** When time is mentioned, it is usually treated as if it were a human possessor.
- I will come when it is two weeks.
 - I'll come in **two weeks'** time. (apostrophe after **weeks**)
- It takes only an hour to drive from here to Ikorodu.
 - Ikorodu is only **an hour's** drive from here. (apostrophe after one **hour**)
- My holiday will span two years.
 - I have **two years'** holiday. (apostrophe after **years**)
- (l) **Sake as possessor:** When **sake** appears, it is treated as a human possessor. When what comes in front of **sake** ends in **s**, do not put any apostrophe and no additional **s**, e.g. for goodness **sake**; for happiness **sake**. But if the word in front of **sake** does not end in **s**, put an apostrophe and **s**, e.g. for the sake of **God** = for **God's** sake. for the sake of **heaven** = for **Heaven's** sake.

- (m) Do not use **my own, our own, her own**, etc. Instead, use **mine, ours, hers**, etc, e.g. It is **hers** not **her own**.
- (n) **Possessive pronouns** do not carry apostrophe at all. Possessive pronouns include: **mine, his, hers, yours, theirs, ours**. Not **your's** faithfully but: **yours** faithfully.
- (o) **Its** means **belonging** to it, whereas **it's** means **it is** or **it has**, e.g:
- (i) **It's** here = It is here.
- (ii) **It's** gone = It has gone.
- The difference is in the use of a verb after **it's**.

2. Contraction Function

The apostrophe also functions for contraction and shortening of words and figures.

Contracted form	Full form
shan't	shall not
can't	cannot (not: can not)
won't	will not
mayn't	may not
oughtn't	ought not
mustn't	must not
hasn't	has not
haven't	have not
I'd go	I would go
I'd gone	I had gone
70	1970
55	1955

3. **Pluralisation Function**

Apostrophe can also pluralise short words, book titles, abbreviations and figures as follows:

- (i) **Short words:** There are four **she's** in your clause.
I used only three **and's** in my sentence.
Words that could be pluralised include: pronouns, prepositions, conjunctions and conditionals.
- (ii) **Book titles:** Book titles can be pluralised, e.g. There are two **The man Died's** in market. (i.e. there are two versions/editions of the book. It does not mean there are two copies).
- (iii) **Abbreviations:** Abbreviations such as **MP, HM, VC**, cannot take apostrophe but they take **s**. So, we have **MPs, HMs, VCs** not: **MP's, or HM's**.

Model Question 1

Invariably, he ends all his letters with amicably. (a) you (b) your's (c) yours' (d) yours (e) your

Clue to answer: Use rule 1 (n).

Model Question 2

Ikorodu is not far from here, it is only an (a) hour of driving (b) hour's drive (c) hour by driving (d) hour in driving (e) hours drive

Clue to answer: Use rule 1(k).

Model Question 3

Will you know if that dog is.....? He has lost a brown and black one. (a) Adebowale's (b) Adebowales' (c) Adebowale's own (d) the Adebowales (e) the adebowale's

Clue to answer: Use rule 1(a).

Model Question 4

The wicked boy threw a stone at the bird smashing..... two legs. (a) its (b) it's (c) it (d) is (e) its'

Clue to answer: Use rule 1(o).

Model Question 5

After we have taken our share, we shall give to them. (a) their (b) theirs (c) theirs (d) there (e) there's

Clue to answer: Use rule 1(n).

Model Question 6

I have received the answer scripts of Peter and John. What about? (a) Ngozi (b) Ngozi's own (c) Ngozi's (d) Ngozis' (e) Ngozi's

Clue to answer: See rule 1(m) and 1(a).

Model Question 7

The choice to go to the University or not is (a) yours' (b) your (c) yours (d) your's

Clue to answer: Use rule 1(n).

HAS, HAVE, HAD: THEIR FUNCTIONS AND USAGE

The three verbs above are anomalous. Candidates will be tested on the difference between **has** and **have** on the one hand and, **has/have** and **had**, on the other.

Has is singular.

Have is plural.

Had is the past tense of **has** and **have**.

	Present		Past
Persons	Has	Have	Had
He	has		had
She	has		had
It	has		had
I	-	have	had
We	-	have	had
You	-	have	had
They	-	have	had

These three verbs have two broad functions:

- (a) **Possession function:** This means that, **has/have/had** may mean **possesses**, e.g.

He **has** a house. (**possesses**)

They **have** a house. (**possess**)

We **had** a house last year. (**possessed**)

You will notice that, after each of the verbs, a noun/noun phrase follows. That is when it shows possession.

(b) **Time-keeping function:** This means that **has/have/had** show time of action and in that case, what comes after **has/have/had** is not a noun/noun phrase but a participle verb, e.g.

- i. He **has** gone. (**gone** is participle verb)
- ii. They **have** gone.
- iii. She **had** gone before I came.

Rules for using has/have/had

1. **Has** and **have** can appear in only one clause (one event), e.g. He **has** gone. (one event)
//**They have gone**// before //**I came**// Two events (not correct)
2. When **has** and **have** are used, no definite time will be used at the adjunct level:
 - i. He **has** gone yesterday. (**yesterday** is definite time) (not correct).
 - ii. The **have** gone last year. (**last year** is definite time) (not correct).

Instead of **has** or **have** in statements such as given above where definite time is mentioned, only a **simple past tense verb** should be used.

"He **has** gone yesterday." becomes "He **went** yesterday".

If, however, **has** or **have** must be used in a clause where there is definite time, **for** or **since** should be introduced before the definite time, e.g.

- i. He **has** gone **SINCE** yesterday. (**since** comes before "yesterday" which is a definite time because of the presence of **has**.)
- ii. They **have** gone **FOR** one year now. (**for** comes before "one year" which is definite time because of the presence of **have**.)

Please note that, you will use **since** when no number of **hours, minutes, years** etc. appears:

Since **yesterday**, not: Since **three** years.

For is used when number of **hours, minutes** etc. appears, e.g. for five **hours**, not: I saw him for **yesterday**.

3. When **Had** is to be used in the sense of the time-keeping function – that is, whenever there is a past participle verb in front of **had**, the statement in which it appears should contain two events, e.g.
 - (i) I went to market. (event 1)
 - (ii) I lost my key. (event 2)

So, **had** can join the two together into one sentence. Whenever **had** is to join such clauses together, one of the following time adverbs should be introduced: **after, before, when, hardly had... when no sooner .. than**, e.g.

(i) and (ii) above will become:

a. I **had** gone to market **BEFORE** I lost my key.

b. I lost my key **AFTER** I **had** gone to market.

No sooner had I gone to market **than** I lost my key.

a. **Hardly had** I gone to market (i) **when** I lost my key.

b. I **had hardly** gone to market **when** I lost my key.

On no occasion should you have only one event when you use **had** in its time-keeping function: I **had** gone (one event) (not correct).

There must be two events. But, when **had** is used to show possession, **had** can be found in a statement of one event, e.g.

I **had** a car last year. (one possession / event)

4. Any verb that comes after **has/have/had** should be in past participle form, e.g. She has **spoken**. (not: She has *speak* or *spoke*)
5. After **has/have/had**, if there is to be a choice between **been** and **being**, **been** should be chosen, e.g.
He has **been** beaten: not
He has **being** beaten.
6. In reported speech, **had** is preferred to **has/have**, e.g.
He **said** that he **had** (not: **has**) spoken.
She **asked** if he **had** (not: **has**) seen her husband.

You will know that it is a reported statement when you see: **said**, **opined**, **asked** (whether), **suggested** (that) etc.

7. In **if** (conditional) sentences, **had** is preferred to **has/have**, e.g. If I seen you, (clause 1) I would have **greeted** you.

Model Question 1

Before the operation, the dentist found that his patient's teeth

- (a) have long decayed (b) have long been decayed (c) have long being decayed (d) had long decayed (e) has long decayed

Clue to answer: Use rule 4.

Model Question 2

We got to the hall after the play (a) is started. (b) was starting. (c) had started. (d) has started. (e) would start.

Clue to answer: Use rule 4.

Model Question 3

The teacher asked if she seen her boyfriend recently.
(a) has (b) have (c) was (d) had

Clue to answer: Use rule 8.

Model Question 4

No sooner had the examination ended the students started vacating the halls of residence. (a) when (b) that (c) than (d) before (e) and

Clue to answer: Use rule 4.

Model Question 5

I him before he came into the room. (a) have seen (b) have not seen (c) used to see (d) see (e) had

Clue to answer: Use rule 4.

Model Question 6

Monisola is sure to pass in September. She hard since the beginning of this term. (a) had been working (b) was working (c) is working (d) would work (e) has been working

Clue to answer: Use rule 3.

Model Question 7

Musa asked Asmau what she since he last saw her.
(a) has been doing (b) had been doing (c) has done (d) was doing
(e) might be doing

Model Question 8

He the book to the library last week. (a) has returned (b) had returned (c) was returning (d) returned (e) was to be returned

Clue to answer: Use rule 2. Note that there is definite time: **last week**. Avoid has/have/had in your answer.

Model Question 9

Mrs Okoro in this school since 1975. (a) taught (b) is teaching (c) was teaching (d) teaches (e) has been teaching

Clue to answer: Use rule 3. (**since** is involved. So, use the rule applicable to it).

Model Question 10

My colleagues before I arrived. (a) started writing (b) wrote (c) had started writing (d) have written (e) have been writing

Clue to answer: Use rule 4.

Model Question 11

We later on discovered that some members another meeting before the one advertised. (a) had holding (b) have held (c) have been holding (d) had held

Clue to answer: Use rule 4.

Model Question 12

Omagbei reported that the examinations before he arrived in the hall. (a) started (b) have started (c) had started (d) are started

Clue to answer: Use rule 4.

Model Question 13

I have been trying to locate you (a) five day now. (b) five days now. (c) since five days now. (d) for five days.

Clue to answer: Use rule 3.

Model Question 14

When I met Amadi yesterday, it was the first time I him for six months. (a) had seen (b) saw (c) have been (d) have been seeing

Clue to answer: Use rule 4.

Model Question 15

The Chemistry teacher seized the girl's comic..... during the laboratory work. (a) which she had been reading (b) which she has been reading (c) which she had read (d) which she is reading

Clue to answer: There are two clauses here. Now decide between use of **has** and **had**. Remember the event is past.

Model Question 16

I would have been surprised if you.....the orange. (a) plucked (b) have plucked (c) had plucked (d) did pluck

Clue to answer: Remember, there is an **if** in the sentence, with two clauses. Choose between **has** and **had**. Use rule 8.

Model Question 17

..... him in the crowd, I would have told you at once. (a) If I will see (b) If I saw (c) If I had seen (d) Should I see

Clue to answer: Use rule 8.

Model Question 18

Before the bill could be settled, Chuwang all the money.
(a) has spent (b) will have spent (c) had spent (d) will spend

Clue to answer: Use rule 4.

Model Question 19

Sibi novels since she came home. (a) is reading
(b) had been reading (c) has read (d) has been reading

Clue to answer: Read and use rule 3. Notice the use of **since** in the question.

Model Question 20

Four engineers on this system since March. (a) worked
(b) are working (c) had worked (d) have been working.

Clue to answer: Use rule 3. Notice the use of **since** in the question.

Model Question 21

The trader complained that he robbed. (a) had been
(b) has been (c) was being (d) is being

Clue to answer: Use rule 4.

Model Question 22

She has been here the past three years. (a) since (b) for
(c) from (d) in

Clue to answer: Use rule 3.

Model Question 23

..... I would have helped you (a) Has it been that you asked me
(b) Had it been that (c) If you have asked me (d) If you had asked me.

Clue to answer: This has to do with conditional sentence. Use rule 8.

TERM VERBS

Certain verbs that have a long span of execution of action and others, a short span. Those that have a short span (moment of carrying them out) are called **short term** verbs and those that have a long moment of action are called **long term** verbs. Consider for example, "leaping over the fence", "taking salute", "washing dishes".

When someone leaps over a fence, it is done in quick tempo because there cannot be any slow motion about it. The same thing applies to "taking a salute", it is a quick action. But "washing dishes" is not.

When a short term verb is used, it will remain in its **base** form, not in **ing** or past tense or inflection **s**, e.g.

- (i) I saw him **leap** over the fence.
- (ii) We watched him **take** a fast salute.
- (iii) They caught her **washing** dishes. (Not: They caught her **wash** dishes)
- (iv) I saw him **come** into the room.

Model Question 1

We saw Ifueko an egg on the wall. (a) smashed
(b) smash (c) smashing (d) smashes

Clue to answer: Read the topic again.

Model Question 2

Of course, we all saw the culprit and hit the man on the head. (a) approach (b) approaches (c) approaching (d) to approach

Clue to answer: Read the topic again.

NE-PLUS ULTRA ADJECTIVES

Sometimes called **ceiling** or **ultimate** adjectives, **ne plus ultra** adjectives are such adjectives that cannot be compared using **than**. It is wrong for example to say, "**This is more triangular than that**", where **triangular** is the adjective. We have already said something has three angles (**triangular**), how can it be more "triangle" than another triangle?

Others in this category are: **right, wrong, correct, senior, junior, superior, inferior, preferable, right, supreme, paramount**, all shapes, including, **circular/round, rectangular, spherical; final** and **unique**. These adjectives are non-gradable.

- (i) He is more **superior** than me. (wrong)
- (ii) He is **superior** to me. (right)
- (iii) I am **inferior** to him. (right)

ADVANCED SPEAKERS' ERRORS AND THEIR CORRECTIONS

It is becoming increasingly difficult these days to determine the correct forms of certain words, phrases, spellings and usage of expressions. This is because errors are now very rampant among even educated speakers of the English Language. These varieties of opinions becloud a consensus and agreement on a common form of usage.

Examiners usually cash in on this gap by seeking to know whether candidates know the correct form of certain words and expressions. The following treatise prescribes current and correct forms and usage of various words and expressions:

Abbreviation:

An abbreviation is a shortened form of a longer word, phrase or title. In modern English, abbreviations involving countries and organizations no longer take full stops between them, e.g.

UNO not **U.N.O**, **USSR** not **U.S.S.R.**

Also, if the last letter of a title appears last in abbreviation; no full-stop must be used, e.g.

Doctor – Dr (without full stop because it is in the full form, **r** comes last. But "professor" will be abbreviated as "Prof." because **f** is not the final letter in the full form.

Abbreviations concerning measurements in metric forms are also not divided by full-stops: **kg**, **cm** etc.

Abide:

Abide means two things. When it means **live**, its past and participle form is **abode**. But, when **abide** means to **obey a regulation**, **by** is its preposition and **abided** is the past and participle form, e.g.

At the meeting, we promised to **abide** by the regulations because the chairman has already **abided** by them.

Abridgement/Abridgment:

Abridgement has two forms as written above but it is commoner with the **e**.

Acquiesce:

Acquiesce takes **in** as preposition to mean **agree to**, e.g. I acquiesced in their decision.

Acquiesce could, however, without 'in', be used and this way, it means **to agree**, e.g. He acquiesced.

Admission/Admittance:

Admittance is the formal form of entering a place and is used for a place that is particular, not open to the public. **Admission** also means entering a place but such entry would be to a public place such as cinema, football field or to a school or club, e.g.

"Admission to the University is strictly by direct entry," said the Vice-Chancellor.

Admission also means **acceptance of blame or of having done or been involved in something**. For example:

His **admission** of the crime was not under duress.

Advice/Advise:

Whereas **advice** is a noun and does not take **to** modal auxiliaries such as **will, would, may, can** etc., **has/have/had** cannot also come before it, e.g.

Advise is a verb which can admit **to** and the auxiliary verb (above) before it:

My **advice** for you is this, work hard.

I wish to **advise** you/ I may **advise** you.

Aeroplane/Airplane/Aircraft:

Whereas **aircraft** is the general name for aeroplane, jet, airbus, glider, helicopters, etc, **aeroplane** is a form of such devices in British English. **Airplane** is the American-English equivalent.

Agenda:

Agenda is singular and its plural, **agendas**, e.g.

We have drawn up **two agendas**, but he, one **agenda**. (not **agendum**)

Ago/Since/For:

When **ago** is used, a number must come before it, e.g. I went there **three days ago**.

Since will be used when a definite time is mentioned. That definite time will, however, not be in figure or number, not:

I have been there **since three days**. (definite time)

For is used when a definite time is mentioned. That time will however be in figure or number, not:

I have been here **for yesterday** (wrong)

I have been here **for three days**. (right)

Caution: **since** and **ago** should not be used together;

I have been there **since three days ago**. (wrong)

I was there three days **ago**. (right)

Agree:

Agree on means, accept decision about something.

Agree with means, accept another person's line of thought, e.g.

I agree with you on that.

Agree with can also mean **be suitable** for as in: The weather **agrees with me**.

Agree to means **consent to do something**, e.g. The pretty girl has **agreed to** my proposal. She **agreed to** marry me.

Alright/Awright/All right:

While **alright** is commonly seen, **all right** is the correct form but there is nothing like **Awright**.

All together/altogether:

All together means put together at a place whereas **altogether** means **all**, completely. For example,

We stored the oranges **all together**, although we didn't bring them **altogether**; some are still in the bag.

Alternative/Option:

Option stands for choice from more than two, whereas **alternative** stands for choices from only two.

Although/Though:

Whereas **although** is formal, **though** is not. **Although** cannot come last in a clause but, **though** can, e.g.

I saw him, **though**. (right)

I saw him **although**. (wrong)

Whenever **though** or **even though** is used, **but** should be avoided in the clause. **Yet** can however be used, although, even **yet** should be avoided:

Although his father is poor, his mother is rich: **Or**

Although his father is poor, yet his mother rich. But not:

Although his father is poor **but** his mother is rich. (wrong)

Among/Amongst:

Whereas **among** is modern, **amongst** is anachronistic and should be avoided.

Angry:

Angry may take the following prepositions: **with, over, about** and **at**.

One can be **angry with** people for something. **Angry at** too can be used when referring to people but is less formal than **angry with**. When we refer to things, **angry** may take **at**, **about** or **over**, but **at** is preferred to the other two:

He was angry **at** my behaviour; but angry **with** me.

Animal:

Animal refers to the most commonly seen of the family of lower animals but wild animals are referred to as beasts. **Beast** often appears in constructions such as **beast of burden**; that is, animals used for carrying loads, e.g. donkey, horse etc.

Anti:

Anti means **against**, e.g. **anti-malaria** drugs. **Ante** sounds like **anti** but is not the same thing with it. **Ante** means **before**. There is **ante-room**, for example, which means a room (small one) leading to a bigger one.

Appendix:

Appendix means two things. It can mean an additional part of a book or a part of the human body. The plural form is either **appendixes** or **appendices**. When it means body part, the plural is **appendixes**; but when it means an additional part of a book, the plural can be **appendices** or **appendixes**.

Appreciate:

Appreciate is a transitive verb which must have its own object, e.g. We appreciate **your efforts**. (**your efforts** is the object)

Arbiter/Arbitrator:

An arbitrator is one who settles disputes between two parties but an **arbiter** is one who has professional authority to decide what should obtain as regards something. Professor Wole Soyinka is an **arbiter** of language.

Artist/Artiste:

An **artiste** is one skilled in drumming, signing, dancing and so on. Whereas, an **artist** is one who draws, paints or does sculpture work.

Atimes:

Mistake is often made about the expression. There are two words: **at** and **times** – never **atimes**.

Authoritarian/Authoritative:

An **authoritarian** person is that, who demands obedience and forces his beliefs on one, whereas **authoritative** means having authority and ability to do something, e.g.

Femi's father is **authoritarian**; he tells him not to watch television. Ade's father is a Doctor of French; he is an **authoritative** speaker of French.

When **authority** is used to refer to a person, **on** is the corresponding preposition. And when so used, **authority** means, **someone who is an expert or who has enough knowledge as to have a say on something**.

Baggage:

When **baggage** is used, it is usually followed by a singular verb and there should not be an **s** after it. This is my **baggage**. The same applies to **luggage**. They are both uncountable nouns.

Bath/Bathe:

Bath is a verb meaning to wash the whole body whereas **bathe** means to wash a part of the body, especially one which is in pain, e.g.

The Doctor ordered that he **bathe** his sprained finger in tepid water.

American English uses **bathe** in both senses of **bath** and **bathe** above, although **bathe** is also used to mean go **swimming**.

Beside/besides:

Beside means **by the side of** whereas **besides** means apart from.
Besides the broken chair, there is another chair **beside** the table.

Brethren/Brothers:

Brethren is used under religious climate to refer to both men and women who are members of a congregation, whereas **brothers** is the correct plural for **brother** and **sisters** for **sister** – in the ordinary sense for both words.

British and American Spelling Patterns:

Spellings in American English differ in some respects from British spellings. Some of the different features are listed below:

- (a) If a verb can take the **ize** or **ise**, American English prefers the former and the British, the latter, e.g. recognize (AmE) recognise (BrE).
- (b) Some verbs, those ending in **p** and **l** in particular, double their last consonant before **ing**, **-ed**, e.g. travelled; travelling (BrE) traveling; traveled (AmE).

American English favours the retention of the single final consonant, as in:

British

American

travelling

traveling

kidnapped

kidnaped

equalled

equaled

counsellor

counselor

- (c) A lot of words which end in **our** in British English end in **or** in American English:

British

American

colour

color

humour

humor

labour

labor

habour

harbor

- (d) Some verbs which end in **-re** are spelt **-er** in American English as shown below:

British

American

centre

center

kilometre

kilometer

meagre

meager

theatre

theater

- (e) There is the practice to replace **ea** and **oea** in words from Greek and Latin by **e** in American English as shown below:

British

American

heamoglobin

hemoglobin

diarrhoea

diarrhea

encyclopeadia

encyclopedia

- (f) Other categories of difference are found in the following:

British

American

axe

ax

catalogue

catalog

programme

program

sceptic

skeptic

plough

plow

Cannot/Can not:

Cannot, written together is the full negative form of **can**, and it means **not possible**, whereas **can not** written separately does **not** mean **not possible**. **Can not** means in addition to:

I **can not** only sing **but also** dance. (I can do both) But:
I **cannot** act on stage because I am shy.

Between:

Some people believe that **between** cannot be used referring to more than two things or people: that it is restricted to use referring only to two things. This is by no means true. **Between** is restricted in use to two things only when the idea of **sharing** out of **something** is involved but in any other cases, **between** can be used for one thousand things/people: e.g.

Share these oranges **between** the new couple. My house is **between** the **mosque, palace, market and church** (sharing is not involved, hence the use of **between** for four things. **Among** is the word to use when sharing involves more than two people, e.g. Share these apples **among** the three sisters.

Biannual/Biennial:

Biannual means **happening** twice a year whereas **Biennial** means **happening** every two years.

Birds of the same feather:

The correct form of this proverb is **birds of a feather**.

Born/Borne:

Born should not be used when **by** follows it, e.g. He was **born** by me (wrong). But instead, he was **borne** by poor parents. But, we can say: He was **born** of American parents. They were **born** in England.

Born on the other hand stands as the past-participle verb form for **bear**, where **bear** means to carry or to give **birth to**. For example: Olu was **borne** by the millionaire businessman. When he won the contest, he was **borne** shoulder high.

Capital: This is used:

- (a) to start a new sentence
- (b) to start names of **people, months/days** of the week, important **festivals** – **Easter, Eld-el-kabir, Christmas**; names of countries.
- (c) to start **titles, Chief-of-Staff, Head-of-State, Vice Chancellor, Governor, Ooni of Ife** etc.
- (d) to begin a salutation: **Sir, Madam**
- (e) to start names of seasons: **Spring, Winter, Summer**

Cattle:

Cattle is a word found only in plural without **s** and it takes a plural verb, e.g. **Cattle** are dirty.

The **cattle** I bought make my compound dirty.

Childish/Childlike:

Childish means, done in the awkward manner of a child – and should not be praised, e.g.

He is twenty five years old but cries at the slightest provocation – such a **childish** attitude.

Childlike means, done in the admirable way of a **child**, e.g. Even when angry, he smiles; that is **childlike**.

Clean/Cleanse:

While **cleanse** is used in a religious sense to mean ablution such as cleansing one of evil spirits, **clean** means to make neat or neat – as an adjective.

Client/Customer:

One who buys from a shop is a **customer** whereas, one who receives services from a professional, e.g. lawyer, tailor, accountant, etc. is

a **client** of such a professional. **Customer** does not mean one who sells regularly to another person (buyer).

Compose/Comprise/Contain/Consist:

Compose can be preceded by **is, was, are, were, can, be**, but then '**of**' will be added to **compose**. With **of** but without the six primary auxiliary verbs above, **Compose** can be used with an object in front of it.

This essay is **composed** of irrelevances. (wrong)

Comprise does not take **of** although, it takes an object, e.g. The team comprises strong boys.

Contain means acts as house for, e.g. This bowl **contains** my breakfast. No preposition is needed in front of it.

Consist can take **of** and **in**, e.g. The team **consist** of strong boys. Where **consist in** means, **stand for**.

Shyness **consists in** cowardice.

Connection/Connexion:

Both spellings are acceptable.

Corps/Corpse:

Corps is a French word, which means **group** and is pronounced without the **ps**. It attracts a singular verb. **Corpse** is a dead body.

Counsel/Council:

Counsel means both **professional advice** and an attorney, lawyer. **Council** refers to a group of people usually administering an organization, establishment or government.

Data:

Data is not found with **s** in plural form and its singular form is **datum**, but **datum** is now anachronistic. **Data** attracts a singular or a plural verb, e.g. Some data were collected.

Deny:

Care should be taken in using deny which means, "to say that something is not true".

"He denied that he did not steal" means "He confirmed that he stole"

"He denied that he stole" means "He refuted the allegation of theft."

Desert/Dessert:

Desert is a place of aridity where nothing grows, whereas **dessert** is the third course of a meal – the sweet/ice-cream course after the main dish.

Deliver a baby:

A woman does not **deliver a baby** but gives birth to a baby. She can however be **delivered of a baby**.

Differ:

With and **from** are two prepositions possible with this verb. **Differ with** means **disagree with**: whereas **differ from** means **different from**. For example:

I differ with him over the answer because, my working method of the Mathematics problem **differs from** his.

Dilemma:

Dilemma means two evils, from which one must pick one. It should not be used in the sense of an ordinary **alternative**. This has to do with two unpleasant things.

Discuss:

The verb **discuss** does not take the preposition **about** or **on**.

We discussed **about** you. (wrong) But:

We **discussed** you.

I **discussed with** Bode.

Doctor/Physician/Surgeon:

Whereas **doctor** is the general name given to those who practise medicine, a **physician** is a **doctor** who treats diseases with tablets,

a **surgeon** treats disease by operating on the patient in the operating theatre. A **physicist** is an expert at **Physics**.

Downward/Downwards:

Downward is an adjective, whereas **downwards** and **downward** could function as adverbs.

It is a **downward** cut. (adjective)

I am going **downwards**. (adverb; British English)

I am going **downward**. (adverb; American English)

Drunk/Drunkard:

Drunk is the past participle of drink. One who is in the habit of losing control of himself as a result of drinking is a **drunkard**, but we can still talk of a drunk man, but no more a **drunken** man.

Due to/Because of:

Due to usually needs a **noun** – not a verb before it: He failed **due to** his laziness. (wrong)

His failure is **due to** his laziness. (**Failure**, preceding **due to**, is a noun.)

Because of refers to the cause of something.

Dying/dyeing: **Dying** is the continuous form of **die**, whereas **Dyeing** is the continuous form of **dye**.

Each other/One another:

Each other and **one another** mean the same thing, and can be interchangeably used. They may not be found together as options to a question where we would expect one of them to be correct; if one is correct, the other is, too.

Some people choose to differentiate between both, maintaining that **each other** is used when there are two entities or referents, **one another** is used when there are more than two entities involved. This is not true because there is no grammatical backing for this assumption. **Each other** can be used when more than two entities are involved, e.g. The six boys love **each other** dearly.

Elder/Older/Eldest:

Elder means more advanced in age in relation to a younger person:
I am ten, he is twelve – he is my **elder** brother.

Older is the comparative of **old** and is used when one compares two things in order of age: Grace and Mercy are friends but Mercy is **older**.

Eldest means, in relation to a group of people already named, an individual is the most advanced in age, whereas **oldest** is the superlative adjective form for **old**. Note that **Junior** or **Senior** does not apply to age, e.g.

He is my **junior** brother. (wrong) But:

He is my **younger** brother/She is my **elder** sister etc.

Every one/Everyone:

Every one means each individual, and can be used of things or people whereas, **everyone** means **all people**, e.g.

- (i) When the pencils scattered on the floor, I picked **every one**.
- (ii) **Everyone** knows what is happening.

Few/A few:

Few is used in the sense of **not many**. **A few** too is used in this sense. Both of them are used with plural count nouns. Plural count nouns are boys, tables, men, children, schools etc. They cannot be used with singular – count nouns or uncountable nouns, e.g. boy, girl, table (singular) or water, information (uncountable etc). Whereas, **few** uses the sign (-), **a few** uses (+). The difference between them is that, **few** shows inadequate number of something whereas **a few** is more than **few**, e.g.

I need a hundred chairs; I got ninety eight, that is **a few** chairs – not up to the required number.

I need a hundred chairs, I got eleven, then I have **few** chairs.

I cannot give you any orange more because I have **few** left.

I can still afford to give you fifty oranges because I have **a few** left.

Fewer/Less:

Less is used in reference to uncountable nouns, e.g. water, information, air, etc, e.g.

There is **less** water in this keg than in that, **Fewer** is used when plural count nouns are used – not uncountable, e.g. There are **fewer boys** (plural count) here **than** are there.

Do not forget that while **fewer** takes plural verbs, **less** takes singular verbs.

Fond/Fund/Find/Found:

Fond usually appears in the phrase **fond of**, i.e. like a lot, e.g. He is **fond** of fried meat.

Fund may mean money as in "government fund" – a noun word.

Fund may also mean to **support a cause, financially** - in this case it is a verb. The past tense for it is **funded**. Note that fond has no present or past tense since it is not a verb.

Find means to get by searching or by chance. The past tense form of **find** is **found**, e.g.

I will **find** out the thief now.

Last week, we **found** out the thief.

Found – Although, this is the past tense of **find**, it may also be used as a present tense on its own. When it is so used, it means, to **establish**, e.g.

(i) I will **found** a school next year.

(ii) Last year we **founded** a church.

So, the past tense of **found** (establish) is **founded**.

Forget at home:

When we talk about concrete things, a statement such as **I forgot my bag at home** does not come in. We can **forget** only abstract things, which cannot be seen with the eyes. We can **leave** concrete things **at home** or **at school** etc, e.g.

I forgot your name (name is abstract).

I left the **register of names** (a concrete thing) at home.

Former/Latter:

When two things are mentioned, the first may be referred to as **former** and the second as **latter** – not later, e.g.

Ade and Johnny are friends: the **former** is a Yoruba boy and the **latter**, an English merchant's son.

Good/Goods:

Good is an adjective that can be used with three prepositions: **at**, **for** and **with**.

Good at is used to show **skill in something**, e.g.

She is **good at** house – keeping/Mathematics.

Good for is used to show **usefulness**, e.g.

Mentholatum is **good for** cold.

This book is **good for** you.

Good with is used to show **capable of caring for**, e.g.

Nurses are **good with** old people.

Goods refers to articles of trade.

Hanged/Hung:

	Present	Past	Past Participle
People	hang	hanged	hanged
Things	hang	hung	hung

E.g. The boy's shirt was **hung** on the window before he himself was **hanged** by the hangman.

His/Her:

When an indefinite pronoun such as **everyone**, **everybody**, **somebody**, **someone** etc. is used, there is often the difficulty of finding the appropriate, corresponding complement for it, e.g. Is it:

Everyone knows **their** names? OR

Everyone knows **his** name? OR

Everyone knows **his/her** name?

Informal English and American English favour **their** with indefinite pronouns, whereas formal use of **everyone** and other indefinite pronouns attract **his** or **her** at the complement level, e.g.

Somebody should tell us **his** or **her** name.

Other indefinite pronouns to which this rule applies are: **each**, **every**, **a person**, **anyone**, **none**.

Hyphen:

A **hyphen**, when applied, shows that two or more words are to be regarded together, as shown below:

- (i) To write two-word figures, e.g. **Thirty-three**, **ninety-four**, **sixty-one**, **two-third** etc.
- (ii) To use between a **prefix** or **suffix** and words, e.g.
Labour is **un-American**.

Prefixes are many, and include **un**, **mis**, **re**, **pro**. Examples of suffixes are, **ness**, **less**, **ish**, **some**, **hood**, etc. When the word coming after a prefix is written in capital, e.g. American, there should be a **hyphen** between the **prefix** and the word starting with a **capital letter**.

Normally, the **prefixes** listed above will not have **any hyphen** coming after them, except if the following word starts with a capital letter. But, there could be: re-enter, re-cover (i.e cover again) as different from recover which means to come back to full health.

Generally, **ex** and **self** are two **prefixes** that will take a **hyphen** in front, e.g.

He is the **ex-governor**; This is my **ex-husband**.
She is **self-conceited**; we are **self-supported**.

- (iii) It is used to form compound adjectives, e.g. **loose-mannered**, **half-hearted**, **battle-ready** etc. It should be noted, however that, this compound adjective must come before a noun before it can take a hyphen. E.g. He is a

strong-willed soldier. Not: 'He is strong willed.' Other compound-adjective components are: **well, better, best, ill, worse, worst**: examples are:

Ours is the **worst-hit** area.

Here are **well-behaved** boys.

Look at the **ill-mannered** secretary.

- (iv) It is used to join several words which stand for the same thing:

The **tarred-on-the-surface** road

Our **big-for-nothing** teacher

The **across-the-Atlantic** trade

- (v) It is used between a verb and preposition (which form a phrasal verb) only when that phrasal verb is a noun, e.g.

He is a **passer-by**.

They are **on-lookers**.

There was a **fall-out** between students and police yesterday.

That you failed is your personal **look-out**.

- (vi) It is used to join a specific number to a noun, with **a** or **the** preceding the number and noun, e.g.

A **two-hour** break.

The **four-men** delegation (wrong).

Note that when it is used this way; the noun after the hyphen will be singular, not: The **four-men** delegation. (wrong)

Index:

The plural of this word is **indices** – when discussing technical topics such as Statistics, Mathematics and so on. But the normal plural is **indexes**.

Indoor/Indoors:

Whereas **indoor** is an adjective describing a particular thing, **indoors** is an adverb showing place, e.g.

Ludo is an **indoor** game. (adjective qualifying game)
I like staying **indoors** always. (adverb of place)

It/it's:

Its means **belonging to it**, whereas **it's** means **it is** or **it has**, depending on the verb in front of it, e.g.

The dog is groaning, **its** forelegs are aching.

It's (it is) unsafe to drive at night.

It's gone away. (it has...)

Lay/Lie:

Lie may mean several things.

It may mean **falsehood**; then, it is a noun, e.g.
'It's a **lie**,' he cried.

Lie also means to be in a prone, prostrate or horizontal, resting position, e.g. when someone is in bed, then, it is a verb. The following forms are applicable:

	Present	Past	Past participle	Continuous
Lie (verb)	lie	lay	lain	lying
Lie (falsehood)	lie	lied	lied	lying

I do not like **lying** on a mattress. I want to **lie** on a mat. Yesterday, I **lay** on a mattress. I had **lain** on it before my back-ache started. Look, if I want to **lie** (say falsehood) I will say that it is good to **lie** on a mattress. But Mrs Falso (our doctor) **lied** that she used to **lie** on a bed before her husband came to tell us that she was only **lying**. (telling lies)

Lay: While **lay** can be at one time, the past form for **lie** (be in prone position), it may also be a present tense of some others things: while **lay** means to spread or leave something somewhere as in:

"Do not **lay** your book here". The present tense is **lay**, past is **laid**, past participle, **laid**. **Lay** can also refer to the process of production of eggs by a bird. Then, the present tense is **lay**, past and past participle, **laid** and continuous tense is **laying**. e.g.

The hen **laid** its eggs before I **lay** on my bed, but if I had **lain** on my bed much earlier, I would not have allowed it to **lay** its eggs.

Lend/borrow/loan:

When something is given out, **lend** is the word. But when that thing is taken or received by the speaker, **borrow** is the word. So, always find out who possesses the thing that must be taken by another, then you will be able to use the appropriate word.

Loan cannot be used in this sense, although, American English permits this:

Please **loan** me your **pen**. (Am E)

Please **lend** (give it out to) me your **pen**.

I want to **borrow** (take it to myself) your **pen**.

Libel/Slander:

Whereas **libel** is any malicious statement against a person or persons written or printed and made available to a party other than the person reported, **slander** is a report of similar nature, not written but spoken.

Lightening/Lightning:

While **lightening** means capable of making something **light** – in **weight** or in **colour** or **complexion**, **lightning** is the **light** that accompanies thunder.

Little/A Little:

The difference between these is similar to the difference between **few** and **a few** but whereas, **few** and **a few** can be used before a

plural count noun, **little** and **a little** can be used before a non count (uncountable) noun only and a singular verb is used with them, e.g.

- (i) There **are** only **few boys** here. (**are** is plural)
- (ii) There **is little** information about them. (**is** is singular)
- (iii) Yesterday I had **a little** water and I gave you several gallons of it, but today, the quantity I have is **little** and I cannot afford to give you more than a jug of it.

Lose/Loose/Loosen/Loosened/Lost:

Lose means to part with something by missing it unintentionally. It is a verb. Its past tense is **Lost**.

Loss is the noun.

Loose is an adjective, which means not tight; slack.

Loosen is a present tense verb, which means to make less tight. The past and past participle tenses of **loosen** is **loosened**, e.g.

I bought a ram and I do not want to **lose** it because its **loss** will be unbearable for me. I **lost** two last Easter because the rope around their necks was **loose**. It became **loose** because my younger brother thought it was too tight and he **loosened** it, although I told him not to **loosen** it.

Lunch/Luncheon/Dinner/Brunch:

Whereas **dinner** is the name given to meals generally, the combination of **breakfast** and **lunch** eaten between the two meals is **brunch**.

Luncheon, on its own, is the name given to formal **lunch** to which, perhaps, some guests feature and it is usually eaten around midday.

Me/I:

The choice between **me** and **I**, **him** and **he**, **me** and **us** etc, is sometimes difficult to make. Pronouns at the subject level should not be used at complement level, vice-versa.

Subjective case	Objective case (Complement level)
He	him
She	her
It	it
I	me
We	us
You	you
They	them

For example, "I saw **them**" is correct, whereas, "I saw **they**" is wrong, because analysing the clause shows that **I** is subject, **saw** is predicator and **them** is the possible pronoun found at the complement (objective case) level.

S	/	P	/	C
I		saw		them

Notice that **they** is not at the complement (objective case) level and, as such, cannot be used.

For more rules concerning this, please refer to the treatise on **CASE** in this book.

Need:

Note that there are two **needs**. One is a modal auxiliary like **can** and **may**, the other is a lexical verb like **go** and **come**. Lexical **need** will have a nominal group item – noun, pronoun, noun phrase, noun clause, nominalisation etc, in front of it, and, it can take **s** and **ed** where appropriate, as long as it is discovered to be lexical.

I **need** (lexical) a **bicycle**. (noun phrase)

He **needs** (lexical) a **bicycle**. (noun phrase)

But modal auxiliary **need** cannot take **s** or **ed** just the way **can**, **should**, **will** etc. cannot take **s** or **ed**. A modal auxiliary **need** will be known by its placement before a lexical verb, e.g.

I **need go** (**go** is lexical), therefore **need** here is modal.

She **need go** (**go** is lexical), therefore **need** here is modal and, as such, cannot take **s**, although the subject, **she**, is singular.

He **need** *read* hard.

He **needs** *some books* to read.

} Compare the difference between the two **needs** here

Neither ... nor:

Either ... or is a correlative conjunction as much as **neither... nor**. The correlatives should not be changed to: **Either... nor X** or **neither... or**.

Further, note that, they are both used only when two things or entities are mentioned –not more than two.

Note: **Neither** Jim, Tony **nor** their teacher **nor** the Principal (wrong)

Not only:

When **not only** is used, it is followed by the correlative part **but also**, e.g.

Not only is she a rogue **but also** aggressive.

Of recent:

This phrase should not replace **recently**.

Off head:

Something cannot be learnt **off head** but, **by heart** and can be said or reeled **off hand** e.g. I learnt the poem **by heart** and can recite it **off hand**.

On the long run:

The correct form is **In the long run**, meaning finally, ultimately.

Outset/Onset:

To mean beginning, **outset** is used, e.g. I warned him at the **outset** of the game.

The **onset of** is also used to mean the beginning, especially of something unpleasant.

Person/People/Personnel/Personal:

Persons is the legal word plural of **person**, whereas **people** is the ordinary plural of it. **Personnel** means "the working category in a place of work"; it does not refer to one person, only **Personal** – an adjective – means relating to an individual.

Possible best:

The avoidance of **best possible** or **possible best** is a wise step in avoiding an error. It is better to say, simply, best.

I will do my **best**; not

I will do my **possible best** [**best possible** is colloquial but to be safe, say "I'll do my utmost."]

Prefer:

Prefer takes **to** as corresponding preposition whereas preference takes **for**, e.g.

I **prefer** orange **to** pine-apple.

I have **preference for** orange **over** pine-apple.

Presently:

Presently means **very soon**. It is not the same thing as **at present** or **now**, or **at the moment**.

Revenge:

One revenges a wrong done to one by oneself but **avenges** a wrong done to another person, on behalf of that person e.g.

She **avenged** her sister's assault.

Round off/round up:

Round off means "to conclude", whereas **round up** means to surround with a view to arresting or capturing.

Senior/Elder: Junior/Younger:

See elder/older/oldest.

Should in case:

Only one of **should** and **in case** could be used at any one time, not the two together, e.g.

Should she come, please wake me up. OR

In case she comes, please wake me up. NOT:

Please wake me up **should in case** she comes. (wrong)

Social/Sociable:

Events are usually referred to as being **social**, while people are said to be **sociable**.

So/Therefore:

It is either **so** or **therefore**, not the two together, e.g.

I am hungry, **so** I am going home. OR

I am hungry, **therefore** I am going home. NOT:

I am hungry, **so therefore** I am going home. (wrong)

Staff:

Staff is a word like **personnel**. It cannot apply to one person just as **army** cannot. A member of staff is possible but hardly **staffer**.

Stationary/Stationery:

Stationary means "not moving" whereas, **stationery** refers to paper and the like.

That/Who/Whom/Whose/Which:

All of these are relative pronouns. They each relate to the noun/noun phrase immediately before them, e.g.

One of the **ladies**, **who** sell tapioca, is here. **Who**, here, refers to **ladies** and that is why the plural verb **sell** has been used to match that plural noun **ladies**.

Some people contend that, **that** cannot apply to people but there is no rule that stipulates this. **That** is used both for things and for people, e.g.

The man **that saw** me has died.

The man **who saw** me has died.

The difference between **who** and **whom** is that, **who** functions at the level of the subject only, **whom** at the level of the complement:

S	P	C
He	knows	whom you are but:

S	P	A
The boy who knows whom you are	is	here

Note that when a **preposition** comes before, **whom** is usually preferred because, even after analysing the clause, one would discover that, the **whom** comes under the complement, e.g.

At **whom** are you looking? (right)

At **who** are you looking? (wrong)

Whose means **someone** or **something** to whom or to which **something** belongs, e.g.

The man **whose** daughter is pregnant ...

The window **whose** frame is weak...

Some people find it unacceptable to use **whose** for non-living things such as **window** (above) but modern English permits this and is even more acceptable than:

The window, **the frame of which** is weak

Which used to be the accepted form. There is however nothing wrong in continuing to use **of which** in the sense in which it is used above.

Thrice/Twice:

Although we could talk of **once**, **twice**, the use of **thrice** should be avoided. Instead, use **three times**. **Thrice** is anachronistic.

Tight friend:

The phrase **tight friend** is unrealistic. Instead, say **bosom friend** or **close friend** or **intimate friend**.

Till/Until:

Till is informal, whereas **until** is formal and cannot be so found in formal writing.

Toward/Towards:

Toward and **Towards** are both prepositions. American English prefers **toward** but British English, **towards**.

Try to/Try and:

Try to is the correct form when it is to mean **make effort to**.

Try and means that two things must be done: first, **try**, second, whatever comes in front of **and**, e.g.

Try and see me means two things.

(i) **try**

(ii) **see me**, but

Try to see me means make efforts to see me. (only one thing)

Unaware/Unawares:

Unaware means **not aware**; ignorant.

But **unawares** is an adverb, which means **without someone knowing**; **unknowingly**, e.g.

He caught me **unawares**. (without my noting his moves or he caught me in such a way that I was surprised because I didn't see him move)

Understanding/Hear:

There is a clear distinction between these two words. One comes before the other: **Hear** comes before **understand**, e.g. An English

man who cannot make out what French man says may say, I cannot **understand** you, but not: I cannot **hear** you.

Upward/Upwards:

As adverbs, both are correct but American English prefers **upward** whereas British English prefers **upwards**. As adjective only, **upward** is correct: e.g. an **upward** step.

With regards/With regard to/Regarding/As regards: -

As regards, regarding and **with regard to** mean **concerning**, e.g.

As regards women, they are weak or

Regarding women, they are weak.

With regards means **love, respect, good wishes**, e.g. I sent the gift **with regards**.

Like/Like say/Such as:

Such as is the best way to illustrate a point. **Like** makes comparison.

Far/Further:

Farther is the comparative of **far**, where **farthest** is the superlative.

Further means **ahead; moving forward**.

Follow/Escort/Join/Accompany:

When the idea is to go somewhere with someone else, use **accompany**.

Advice:

Advice is a noun, **advise** is a verb. There is no such thing as **Advices** (noun) but a piece of advice, e.g. He gave **me two pieces** of advice.

Dear life:

This should not be preceded by a possessive adjective such as **his, your, their**, neither should **life** be changed to **lives**. They all ran for **dear life**. Not: They all ran for **their dear lives**. (wrong)

Elite:
This is a collective noun as **clergy, staff**. It cannot apply to only an individual. An influential individual is an **elitist**. Elite cannot take an s at the back.

I'm coming:
It is better to say **I will be with you in a moment**.

Suppose:
Suppose, when used to mean **think**, as in: "I **suppose** you are fine", does not require **is/was/are/were/am** before or after it. But when **suppose** means expected as in: you are **supposed** to pass, **suppose** must change to **supposed** and it takes **is/was/are/were/am** before it.

You **are supposed** to pass. Not: You **suppose** to pass. (wrong)

Worth:

It can appear in statements such as; it is worth seeing. Before **worth** is used in the sense it is used above, use **is/was/are/were/am**, e.g.

It **is worth** the trouble, not: it **worth** the trouble. In place of **is**, use **be + worth + ing**

More grease to your elbow:

This idiom is actually **more power to your elbow**.

Now, try to answer the following questions:

Model Question 1

The members of the panel were (a) discussing about it.
(b) discussing on it. (c) discussing upon it. (d) discussing around it.

Clue to answer: See Discuss.

Model Question 2

It was a long poem but he learnt it..... (a) off head. (b) in memory. (c) by heart. (d) at heat. (e) from memory.

Clue to answer: See **Off-head**.

Model Question 3

We ought to stay awaythe robbers come back. (a) provided (b) should in case (c) although (d) in case (e) since

Clue to answer: See **Should in case**.

Model Question 4

The Head of State in his New Year Broadcast to the nation emphasized the need for Nigerians to regard as members of the same family. (a) themselves (b) one another (c) each other (d) yourselves (e) theirselves

Clue to answer: See **Each other/ One another**.

Model Question 5

A societyindividuals each of whom has his attributes and distinct characteristics. (a) is constituted of (b) comprise of (c) consist of (d) contains of (e) is made from

Clue to answer: See **Comprise/Consist**.

Model Question 6

I was able to Olu my book because he promised to return it the following day. (a) borrow (b) give (c) lend (d) lease (e) secure

Clue to answer: See **Lend/Borrow**.

Model Question 7

It was a blind alley. I could not walk any (a) far (b) farthest
(c) furthest (d) farther (e) further

Clue to answer: See Far/Further.

Model Question 8

I always prefer the theatre..... the cinema. (a) than (b) then
(c) on top of (d) before (e) to

Clue to answer: See Prefer.

Model Question 9

Give me a minute to think. I can't remember the answer.....
(a) out of bound. (b) ahead. (c) off hand. (d) to hand. (e) off head.

Clue to answer: See Off head / By heart.

Model Question 10

Our Literature Master said that he would show us a film on Macbeth.
The film will..... (a) worth seeing (b) worth seeing it (c) be
worth to see (d) be worth seeing (e) be worthy seeing

Clue to answer: See Worth.

Model Question 11

My wife and I met.....on a ship going to Liberia (a) ourselves
(b) one another (c) each other (d) ourself

Clue to answer: See Each other.

Model Question 12

When he had arranged the furniture he.....the picture on the
wall. (a) hanged (b) hung (c) hang (d) hunged

Clue to answer: See Hang/Hung/Hanged.

Model Question 13

I forgot to bring a pen with me. Would you pleaseme yours?
(a) borrow (b) loan (c) provide (d) lend

Clue to answer: See **Lend/Borrow/Loan.**

Model Question 14

If you are going to the market, may Iplease? (a) follow you
(b) come with you (c) come by you (d) come as your second

Clue to answer: See **Escort.**

Model Question 15

Wada said that two of his chickens..... eggs yesterday morning.
(a) layed (b) lied (c) laid (d) lain

Clue to answer: See **Lay/Laid.**

Model Question 16

The ceremony was rounded.....very late. (a) up (b) off (c) of (d)
out

Clue to answer: See **Round up/Round off.**

Model Question 17

My.....brother intends to get married in December. (a) senior
(b) elder (c) older (d) oldest

Clue to answer: See **Elder/Older**

Model Question 18

The man insisted on giving unsolicited.....(a) advice (b) advices
(c) advise (d) advises

Clue to answer: See **Advice/Advise**.

Model Question 19

If you don't want to.....your car to robbers, then don't travel in the night. (a) loose (b) loss (c) lose (d) lost

Clue to answer: See **Lose/Loose**.

Model Question 20

The event reported in the newspaper did not happen years ago; they..... (a) are of recent. (b) had happened recent. (c) are recent. (d) recently happened.

Clue to answer: See **Of Recent**.

Model Question 21

When the driver lost control of his vehicle, the pedestrians began to run for..... (a) their dear lives. (b) their dear life. (c) dear lives. (d) dear life.

Clue to answer: See **Dear life**.

Model Question 22

My uncle is one of the.....of the society. (a) elitists (b) elites (c) elite (d) elitist

Clue to answer: See **Elite/Elitist**.

Model Question 23

Yemi said "I'm coming" to her friend, Biola, who was waiting for her, instead of saying..... (a) wait for me in a moment (b) I will come (c) I'll be with you in a moment (d) I'll come now

Clue to answer: See **I'm coming**.

Model Question 24

Atuk, without giving any hint as to what he intended to do, went and..... himself. (a) hung (b) hang (c) hanged (d) hunged

Clue to answer: See **Hang/Hung**.

Model Question 25

The.....was filed.....the Ilorin Magistrate Court. (a) suit/in (b) case/in (c) suit/at (d) case/at

Clue to answer: See **Suit**.

Model Question 26

People who live by.....what loneliness is like. (a) each other know (b) one another know (c) oneself knows (d) themselves know

Clue to answer: See **Each other**.

Model Question 27

Although the manager is busy right now, he will be with you (a) immediately. (b) soon. (c) without delay. (d) right away.

Clue to answer: See **Presently**.

Model Questions 28

There are..... on spelling and pronunciation at the end of the book. (a) appendixes (b) appendix (c) appendices (d) appendixes

Clue to answer: See **Appendix**.

Model Question 29

She usually works hard but..... she could be very lazy (a) at times (b) atimes (c) attimes (d) at time

Clue to answer: See **Atimes**.

Model Question 30

I would like to..... my father to Kaduna. (a) accompany (b) follow
(c) escort (d) join

Clue to answer: See **Escort**.

Model Question 31

During the examination, a student.....more answer sheets.
(a) requested (b) requested for (c) requests for (d) request

Clue to answer: See **Request (for)**.

Model Question 32

This is to congratulate you on your success in the last examination and to wish you (a) more grease to your elbow. (b) more power to your elbow. (c) some grease on your elbow. (d) some power to your elbow.

Clue to answer: See **More grease to your elbow**.

Model Question 33

I had hardly.....down to sleep when I heard the gunshot. (a) lay
(b) lied (c) lain (d) laid

Clue to answer: See **Lay/Laid/Lain**.

Model Question 34

Kindly.....me your book because my friend has mine.
(a) borrow/borrowed (b) borrow/lent (c) lend/lent (d) lend/borrowed

Clue to answer: See **Borrow/Lend/Loan**.

Model Question 35

I am admission to the university this year. (a) seeking on
(b) seeking for (c) seeking at (d) seeking

Clue to answer: Read about **seek**.

Model Question 36

The man declared his intention from the (a) onset (b) inset
(c) outset (d) offset

Clue to answer: See **outset/onset**.

Model Question 37

Audu fought with his (a) senior (b) older (c) elder (d) bigger)
brother

Clue to answer: See **Elder / Older / Eldest**.

Model Question 38

The new school is not provided with (a) an equipment.
(b) equipments. (c) enough equipment. (d) enough equipments.

Clue to answer: **Equipment** is an uncountable noun. Uncountable nouns do not take **s** after them. Others in this category are **information, advice, baggage, luggage, all liquids: tea, water, kerosene, petrol; traffic, machinery, work, damage, money, duty** (charges on imports) **data, fruit, knowledge, staff, evidence, personnel, apparatus** and so on.

Model Question 39

The loquacious young lad reeled off all the names of the players.....
(a) off head. (b) at hand. (c) at heart. (d) off hand.

Clue to answer: See **Off head**.

Model Question 40

..... you come early to the new house, clean up my flat. (a) By chance (b) Should (c) While (d) Should in case

Clue to answer : See **Should in case**.

Model Question 41

More as you campaign for press freedom. (a) energy (b) effort (c) power (d) grease to your elbow

Clue to answer : See **Power**.

Model Question 42

The **reason** why he was not offered admission was he had no results. (a) because (b) that (c) when (d) owing to

Clue to answer : See **Due to**.

Model Question 43

Be careful not to this money. (a) lose (b) loose (c) loss (d) lost

Clue to answer : See **Lose / Loose / Loosen / Loosened / Lost**.

Model Question 44

How is the new editor on with his work. (a) pushing (b) going (c) getting (d) moving

Clue to answer : One **gets on** with his/her work, not **go on** or **move on with** or **push on with** one's job or affairs.

WORD FACTORY

NEAREST-IN-MEANING-TO AND OPPOSITE-IN-MEANING-TO TYPES OF QUESTIONS: A SCIENTIFIC APPROACH

The aspect under which candidates are expected to find a word or phrase to replace another word normally gives many candidates a lot of headache. This is especially so, when a candidate does not know the meaning of the word which he/she is to replace by another word.

It also happens usually, that even if the candidate knows the meaning of the underlined word, he or she may not know how to forge a contextual or figurative meaning from the word, which is why almost all four options of a question usually look alike. The candidate is, therefore, at a crossroads about the answer.

There is an approach to this type of question that guarantees the candidates the correct answer. The methods are those of **word-manufacture technique** and **elimination by status**. These method.

(a) **The Word-manufacture technique:**

This technique enables the candidate to determine the meaning of even the strangest word, because it shows him/her how to trace the origin of that word. Once a candidate can determine the meaning of an underlined word, there is little problem in finding its opposite or the one nearest in meaning to it in the options. For example, what do the following words mean?

(a) Malodorous (b) Minimart (c) Interdenominationalism (the longest word in the dictionary) (d) Surcharge (e) Brunch.

Before we can understand the word-manufacture method, we shall discuss certain concepts, namely:

Synonym: A synonym is a word which has the same meaning as another. As a matter of fact, no "duplicate" of any word could be found, that is, there is no direct, accurate substitute for any word; all we can have is a word, very NEAR in meaning to the one in question.

Examples of synonymous words are:

go = proceed

stop = halt

Antonym: An Antonym is a word which is contrary or opposite in meaning to another, e.g.

hot = cold

short = tall

good = bad

Homophone: **Homo** means **same** or **identical**, while **phone** means **speech sound**. So, homophones are words which sound alike but are different in meaning, e.g.

piece and **peace**;

fare and **fair**;

hare and **hair**; etc.

Polysemic Entries: These are words, which have more than one meaning e.g. **ball**, **bank**, **bridge**, **philosophy**, etc.

Bridge, for example, has, at least, five meanings. This is why it will be preposterous and inappropriate for any examiner to ask for the meaning of an uncontextualised word. When any polysemic word is put in a sentence, the context (words surrounding it) will help bring out its meaning.

Foreign words: The English Language has its origin in many histories and some of the words being currently used in the language have traces of relation with their parent words from the mother language. Some of the origins are French and Greek languages. So, till now, there are words such as:

rendezvous	-	French
corps	-	French
coup d'etat	-	French
suicide	-	French
regal	-	Latin
pater	-	Latin.

Suicide, for example, has a French origin. **Sui** means **self** as in the French phrase **je suis**. **Cide** means **kill**. So, to kill oneself is **suicide**.

We shall now examine the key principles in word manufacture.

Root/Base: **Root or Base** is the smallest indivisible part of a long word which can take part in word formation. It is a meaningful part of a word, from which other (longer) words are formed, e.g.

MALODOROUS

The base word is **ODOUR** but because more letters **mal** and **ous** have been added, it has changed from **odour** to **odor**, nonetheless, it is recognised as **odour**.

Odour means **smell**. If we are able to recognise the "base" of any long word, we can go on to analyse, thus:

MAL-ODOR-OUS

Mal is a prefix which means **bad** while **ous** is a suffix for adjectives. It means, therefore, that **malodorous** is something that has a **bad smell**, as in:

Malodorous gutter.

Malodorous garbage bin.

For more practice, identify the base words in the following:

- i. international
- ii. irresponsibility
- iii. discontentment
- iv. unfriendliness

AFFIXATION: **Affixation** is the addition of some letters before or after a base word, e.g.

MALODOROUS: We have said that **Odor** (Odour) is the root/base word. **Mal** comes before; **ous** comes after it. The system of fixing these letters before and after the root/base word is affixation.

PREFIX: **Pre** means **before**. Prefix therefore means the fixing of letters before a root, e.g. **Mal** in **Mal-odor-ous**.

SUFFIX: Suffix is the fixing of letter(s) after a root, e.g. **ous** in **Mal-odor-ous**.

Now, identify the prefixes and suffixes in the following:

- i. Unreadiness
- ii. Disqualification
- iii. Interdenominationalism
- iv. Abnormality
- v. Unfriendliness

You need to first look for the base/root before you can arrive at the prefixes and suffixes.

Prefix	Meaning	Combined with	Example
A-	lacking in	(a) adjectives (b) nouns	asocial , asocial asymmetry
Non-	not with various word classes	'non' + adj/noun	non-Nigerian
In-	the opposite of	adjectives	Indifferent , inactive
Un-	not opposite of	adjectives, participles	unkind , un- assuring
Dis-	not opposite	adjectives, verbs	disgraceful , disallow
De-	to bring action back	verbs, abstract nouns	derobe , dehumanization
Dis-	to reverse an action or deprive of	verbs, participles, noun	disqualify , disregard , dishonour
Pseudo-	false or imitation	nouns, adjectives	pseudopodia
Mal-	bad or badly	verbs, abstract nouns, participles, adjectives	maltreat , maltreatment , malodorous
Mis-	wrongly, astray	verbs, abstract nouns, participles	misunderstand , misleading
Under-	too little	verbs, participles	underrate , underprivileged

Over-	too much	verbs, participles, adjectives	overstress, overstaffed, overconfident
Out-	to do something longer, better, faster than	intransitive verbs	outnumber, outclass
Arch-	great, highest	nouns	archangel, archbishop
Super-	above better	nouns	superstar, supermarket, supernatural
Ultra-	extremely beyond	nouns	minimart, (minimarket)
Sub-	less than		subordinate, substandard
Hyper	extremely	adjectives	hyperactive
Co-	with	verbs, nouns	co-ordinate, co-tenant
Counter-	against or in opposition to,	verbs, abstract nouns	counteract counterindication
Pro-	for, on the side of	nouns, adjectives	pro-American pro-socialist
Sub-	beneath, lesser in rank	nouns, adjectives, verbs	submarine, substandard

Inter-	between	verbs, nouns, adjectives	interact, interdependence interdenomi- national
Trans-	across from one place	verbs, adjectives	transcontinental
Super-	over	nouns	superstructure
Ex-	former	nouns (human only)	ex-president
Fore-	before	verbs, abstract nouns	restructure, replacement
Uni, Mono	one		unilateral, monopoly
Bi-, Di-	two		bilateral, diagonal
Multi-			multinational
Poly-	many		polytechnic
Vice-	deputy		vice-president
Semi-	half		semiliterate
Neo-	new		neo-colonialism
Auto-	self		autograph, automobile
Pan-	all, together		pan-Asian pan-African
Proto-	first, original		prototype

SUFFIXES AND THEIR USES

-STER	person engaged in a particular work	e.g. gangster
-EER	occupation	e.g. engineer
-ER	inhabitant of or doer of	e.g. londoner, manager
-LET	small, unimportant	e.g. booklet, novelette
-ETTE	(a) small, or compact (b) female gender of something	e.g. kitchenette e.g. usherette
-ESS	female	e.g. princess, manageress
-HOOD	status, position	e.g. childhood, boyhood
-SHIP	status or condition	e.g. scholarship, premiership
-DOM	domain, state	e.g. kingdom, queendom
-OCRACY	system of government	e.g. aristocracy, gerontocracy
-IST	member of	e.g. capitalist, specialist
-ISM	principle, attitude	e.g. awoism, communism
-EE	somebody for something	e.g. employee, interviewee
-ATION	(a) state, action (b) institution	e.g. privatisation, e.g. organisation
-MENT	state, action, activity, or result of activity	e.g. embarrassment
-NESS	state, quality	e.g. kindness

-ITY	state, quality	e.g. purity
-IFY	to do something	e.g. simplify
-IZE/ISE	to do something	e.g. visualize, AmE e.g. visualise, BrE
-EN	make to become	e.g. lighten, straighten
-FUL	having the qualities of	e.g. useful, helpful
-LIKE	having the qualities of	e.g. Godlike
-LESS	without	e.g. painless
-LY	having the qualities of	e.g. mainly
-Y	like or covered with	e.g. hairy
-ISH	having the character of	e.g. foolish
-WARD(S)	manner/direction	e.g. forward
-WISE	(a) in the manner of (b) from the point of view of	e.g. clockwise e.g. economy-wise

You now understand how, even if you did not know the meaning of a word, you can analyse it to arrive at its meaning. That is the first step – that is, determining the meaning of a word when finding its synonym or antonym.

(b) **The Elimination-by-status method**

This second method – a continuation of the word manufacture-helps a candidate to choose his answers under **nearest-in-meaning-to** or **opposite-in-meaning-to** types of questions.

For example, attempt the following, giving the option opposite in meaning to the words in bold type:

1. The gutter is **malodorous**.
(a) dirty (b) untidy (c) neat (d) disused (e) indecent

2. The bishop was **derobed** last year.
(a) insulted (b) enthroned (c) dishonoured (d) killed
(e) imprisoned

Now, first notice that in the two questions, the statements do not reveal the meaning of **malodorous** and **derobed**. It is deliberate. No examiner will want you to detect the meaning through the context easily. It would have been different if, for example, the first question was:

"The gutter has not been washed for two months: it is **malodorous**."

Here, you would quickly determine that the gutter is dirty and that the opposite of dirty is **clean**. But the question has no revealing context. So, you need to analyse the word:

Mal - prefix = bad

Odor - base word = smell

Ous - suffix = adjective

So, **malodorous** is **smelling badly**.

In (2) above, **derobe** could be analysed as **de**-prefix, meaning opposite of/to reverse action. (Check again from "prefixes and their uses.")

robe is a base word, and a verb, which means to put a dress of office on someone's shoulder as in: The king was **robed** (not: robbed); i.e. dressed in the official dress/regalia. In other words, he was made a king or enthroned.

So, the opposite of **dethrone** is **enthroned** which, is the answer. — **en** is a prefix which helps us to turn a word into a verb. Remember, verbs such as **de** help turn something into negative.

By status, we mean whether the word is positive or negative. A word is positive if it brings a sense of morality, fairness or fortune.

A word is negative if it is obscene or immoral or if it shows misfortune,
e.g.

good	-	positive
bad	-	negative
ill	-	negative
health	-	positive
return	-	positive
stole	-	negative

Now, let's go back to questions 1 and 2. Look at which words are positive and which are negative among the options:

1. (a) dirty - negative
- (b) untidy - negative (because of **un**)
- (c) neat - positive
- (d) disused - negative
- (e) indecent - negative (because of **in**)

Only (c) is positive. You were asked to look for the opposite of **malodorous** and **derobed**.

Malodorous is negative (because of **mal** which means bad).

Also, **derobe** is negative (because of **de** which is a negative prefix).

So, it means that our answers for the two questions should be positive. And, judging from your analysis of status of the words, in the options of the first question, **neat** is the only positive word therefore, it is the answer. You can get the answer to the second question this way.

It must be said however, that not all underlined words in a question can lend themselves to word manufacture analysis. For example, the word nearest in meaning to **surtax** (surcharge) should be a negative word, but the word opposite in meaning to it is **undercharge**. **Overcharge** is nearest in meaning, while **undercharge** is opposite in meaning to **surtax**.

(c) Contextualisation or Environment

The environment of any word is the word, or the set of words, that comes before and after that word. In every case, the context, environment, in which a word is used is the greatest factor that determines the meaning of the word.

You can use this method if the question is so formed as to reveal the meaning of the underlined word. Although in many cases, the clue or the meaning of a word underlined may not be arrived at, in the way the question is set.

For example, let us take this:

What is the word nearest in meaning to the following emboldened words?

The photographer **enlarged** the photograph but the building engineer could not the house. (a) maximize (b) prolong (c) extend (d) inflate (e) exaggerate

"The company that words keep" is a principle in semantics and, as such, we do not talk of **prolonging** a house but can prolong a **discussion** or **stay**; we cannot **maximize** a house but profit; we can not **inflate** a house but can inflate **prices**; we do not **exaggerate** a house but can exaggerate an **event**, but the compound of a house can be extended.

The words **maximize**, **prolong**, **inflate** and **exaggerate** all point to one thing — to make bigger in proportion but it should be put it mind that certain words go in certain situations.

Finally, using the methods of manufacture of words in the word factory will enable you arrive at the correct answer.

It is not enough to learn words and their opposites. One sure way of arriving at the answer in these types of questions is to understand the principles of word formation and principles of environment.

CASE

Do you say **it's I** or **it's me**, on behalf of **us students** or on behalf of **we students**; the matter is **between you** and **I** or **between you** and **me**, and so on?

There are two broad levels of case here, namely;

Subjective case

He

She

It

We

You

They

I

Objective case

Him

Her

It

Us

You

Them

me

The rules are the following:

1. If there is a question which **does not show that someone did something**, it is answered with the objective case, e.g.
A: Who is at the door? (no action here)
B: **It's me.**
2. If in the question, **action** is implied, it is answered with the subjective case, e.g.
A: Who stole the ball?
B: **It's I** (who **stole** it).
3. The **objective** case follows **prepositions**. e.g. Share the oranges **between him** (not: **he**) and **them** (not: **they**). **Between** is a preposition.

4. After the word **than**, the question is settled when the statement is written in full, e.g. He is older **than** me. Usually, nothing should follow the word in the objective case but a verb could still follow the subjective case, e.g. He likes Ade more than I (like Ade).
5. After **may have** or **could have** or any such statement, the **subjective case** is used, e.g.
A: Do you think Olu did it?
B: It **may have** been **he** (who did it), not: it may have been him.
6. After **such as**, the subject case follows: I like boys such as **he** (not: him).
7. After **like**, the objective case is used: I admire girls like **her** (not: she).
8. "**In the name of**" or "**on behalf of**" is followed by the objective case, e.g. I present this gift to you on behalf of **us** (not: we) students.
9. Is it, "The teacher called Ade and me or Ade and I"? Called is a predicator, **Ade and me** are in objective case, e.g. He called Ade and (he called) **me**.
10. If what you refer to is pleasant, the other person's name is mentioned first for courtesy purposes: **Ayo** and I (not: I and **Ayo**) succeeded.

Model Question 1

Remember, this matter is strictly (a) between you and I. (b) among you and I. (c) among you and me. (d) between you and me. (e) between you and myself.

Clue to answer: Use rule 3.

Model Question 2

The teacher invited Akpan and to his office. (a) myself (b) me
(c) I (d) himself

Clue to answer: If you analyse this statement in the SPCA pattern, it will be like this:

S **P** **C** **A**
The teacher invited Akpan and _____ to his office

The gap is under complement. Under the **complement** is the **objective case**. So, choose a pronoun appropriate from the objective options.

Model Question 3

Baba and participated in the tournament. (a) him (b) his
(c) he (d) he's

Clue to answer: Analyse the question statement thus:

S **P** **C**
Baba and _____ participated in the tournament

So, use the appropriate subjective pronoun since the gap (for the answer) is under 'S'. Would you say, starting a sentence:

Him participated or

He participated or

His participated?

Model Question 4

It was who fought the civil war. (a) they (b) them (c) those
(d) their's

Clue to answer: Use rule 2.

Model Question 5

The physicians have more people in Waiting Room than have ever had. (a) his/he (b) there/they (c) their/they (d) them/they

Clue to answer. Use rule 4.

Model Question 6

Those men helped Dupe and (a) myself. (b) I. (c) me. (d) we.

Clue to answer. You will analyse the clause as usual to determine where the gap is, that is, is it under "S" or "C". Don't forget, if it comes under S you will use a subjective case item. But if it comes under the C, you will use the objectives case.

S		P		C
Those men		helped		Dupe and

CONDITIONAL CLAUSES

You will recognise a conditional statement by looking for the following: **If, provided (that), unless, in case**. There are two kinds of conditions. They are as follows:

Real condition: If the action described here is **practicable** or **has happened**, it is **real**. If this is so, the verbs in the two clauses of that statement of condition should be in the **present tense**, e.g.

If I **meet** you (clause 1) I **will** beat you (clause 2). **meet** and **will** are present.

Unreal condition: It is the condition that expresses action which **has not happened** and which is **unlikely to happen**. The verbs in the two clauses of the statement should be in the **past**, e.g.

If a lion **came** into this room, **we would** talk about it for weeks.

Came and **would** are past forms of the verbs **come** and **will**, and this shows that the action did not happen.

Generally, the question may omit the verb in one of two clauses and expect you to supply the appropriate verb: check the tense in which the other verb is. And in another way, if the two verbs have been supplied, you may be asked to say the implication of the statement, e.g. If I **saw** the thief, I **would** catch him (Here, **saw** and **would** are in the past, showing that it did not happen).

Model Question 1

If I went to the cinema, I early. (a) shall return (b) am returning
(c) would return (d) had returned (e) may return

Clue to answer: Note that in clause 1, **went** is past tense. I in the second clause of the statement of the question should attract a past tense verb too.

Model Question 2

Had she asked me earlier, I might have been able to employ him.
(a) I employed her. (b) I did not employ him. (c) I did not employ her.
(d) I employed him. (e) employed her.

Clue to answer: This is another method of asking a question under conditionals. It is called **interpretation**. To interpret well, you should know the difference between real and unreal conditions.

Model Question 3

If one day, we would talk about it for weeks. (a) a lion would be coming into this room (b) a lion was coming into this room (c) a lion came into this room (d) a lion is coming into this room (e) a lion is going to come into this room

Clue to answer: This is an **unreal condition** as you can see. Use rules 2 and 3.

Model Question 4

It easier, if he told us himself. (a) would be (b) would have been (c) would had been (d) will be

Clue to answer: Is this a real or unreal condition? Your answer to this question will help you to reach the correct answer.

Please note that: **will/would/could/shall/should** cannot co-exist with **had**, e.g. It **would had been**... (wrong)

Model Question 5

If the boys arrived early enough, the match (a) would have been played. (b) will be played. (c) will have to be played. (d) would be played.

Clue to answer: This is an unreal condition. Use rule 2.

Model Question 6

If he were here, it could have been more fun.

- (a) There was no fun because he was not present.
- (b) He was being expected to supply more fun.
- (c) He did not show up and so the occasion lacked fun.
- (d) His absence meant less fun.

Clue to answer: The statement of the question starts with **if**, a marker of condition. The verbs used in the two clauses are both in past form: **were** and **could** (have been), showing an **UNREAL** condition.

Model Question 7

Had he considered his public image carefully, he for his opponent in the election. (a) should have stepped down (b) might have stood aside (c) would have stood down (d) would have stepped aside

Clue to answer: Had he considered his public image is the same as, **if he had considered his public image** Check **unreal condition** again.

CONCESSIONS

You can recognize a statement concession by looking for the following: (al) **though, even though, while, whereas, despite that, fact that, in spite of, notwithstanding, however, nevertheless** and **albeit**.

A concession is bringing two opposite ideas together using one of the above – listed items. If you find any one of them in any statement, you should know that there are two clauses. One is positive, the other, negative. It is positive if it is good or beneficial, negative if it is not.

Although he is **rich** (clause 1 – positive). The woman is **poor** (clause 2 – negative). You can add a concession marker: **Although** he is **rich**, the woman is **poor**.

Caution: When (al) **though, even though** is used, the use of **but** should be thoroughly avoided. **Yet** may be used. Strictly speaking, both **yet** and **but** should be avoided. E.g.

Although he is brilliant **but** he failed. (wrong) Rather say: **Although** he is brilliant, he failed.

Other deep markers of concession include: **come what may, try as you will, say what you will** i.e. Whatever you say against my plans, I will marry her. **For all you say**, i.e. although you say bad things, e.g. **For all you say**, I will marry her.

Model Question

The future of the company is though many seem about it. (a) promising / nostalgic (b) dicy / unsatisfied (c) okay / optimistic (d) rosy / pessimistic

Clue to answer: Note that **though** is an express marker of concession, that is, two opposite statements brought together by linguistic force. So, the option to be taken must contain two words, one opposite to the other.

QUESTION TAGS

Note the following:

Subject – the doer or performer of any action

Primary auxiliaries – is, was, are, were, and am

Modal auxiliaries – will-would, may-might, shall-should, can-could, must-ought to, need-need, dare-dare (present and past tense, respectively).

Operator – An operator is the word you use in changing a statement to a question, e.g. I can dance. **Can** I dance? (**can** is the operator). So, the following may function as operators: **all modal auxiliaries**, **all primary auxiliaries** and **has/have/had**. Lexical verbs such as **go, come, dance** cannot.

Now, when you have a **statement**, the second part is usually a **question**. A statement or question is **positive** if it **does not** carry the negative particle **not**, e.g. He goes home.

A statement or question is negative if it has the negative particle **not**, e.g. He does **not** go home.

Now, the rules:

1. If the **statement** is **positive**, the **question** should be **negative**, e.g. He can do it (+**statement**), **can't he** (do it)? (- **question**)
2. If the **statement** is **negative**, the **question** should be **positive**. He cannot beat me (- **statement**), **can he** (beat me)? (+**question**)
3. If there is only a lexical verb but no operator in the statement, **do, does** or **did** is used, e.g.

He likes oranges (+statement without operator), doesn't he? (-question using **does**)

You see that **likes** attracts **does**, **like** will attract **do**, **liked** will attract **did**. So, watch the lexical verb well to be able to choose between **do**, **does** and **did**.

4. When **must**, **ought to** or **should** is used to mean necessary, the following statement or question will be **need** or **needn't**, as in: **Must** you always tell lies? No, I **needn't** (not: No, I **mustn't**).
5. In **yes/no** questions, you do not use **not** with **yes** or positive with **no**, e.g.
A: You don't know him? (Do you know him?)
B: **Yes**, I **do** or **No**, I **don't**.
6. **Do you mind** means **do you think it is bad if...**
A: Do you mind a cup of tea? (Do you think it is bad if I give you a cup of tea?)
B: **No**. I **don't** (think it is bad).
7. If **there** is the **subject** of the clause, **there** should be returned in the second part, e.g.
There are four boys here. (+ **statement**)
Aren't there? (question with **there** returned)
8. If the statement starts with **let us**, the second part will be **shall + subject**: e.g. **Let's go**, shall we!
9. If the statement involves **used to**, **did** or **didn't** should be used, e.g.
We used to cry before, **didn't we?**

Model Question 1

The Managing Director did not pay his staff last month,?
(a) didn't he (b) had he not (c) is not it (d) did he (e) has he

Clue to answer: The statement is negative. Use rule 1.

Model Question 2

Must you say 'Good Morning' to everybody in the street? No,
(a) I needn't (b) I mustn't (c) I can't (d) I do not need (e) I'll have to

Clue to answer: Use rule 4.

Model Question 3

We used to go to that club on Saturday night,? (a) isn't it (b) didn't we (c) don't we (d) aren't we (e) used we not

Clue to answer: Use rule 9.

Model Question 4

It had been raining before the match started,? (a) isn't it (b) hasn't it (c) hadn't it (d) wasn't it (e) is it

Clue to answer: Use rule 1.

Model Question 5

The students haven't come back from the library,? (a) isn't it (b) have they (c) is it (d) had they (e) haven't they

Clue to answer: Here you have a negative statement. Use rule 2.

Model Question 6

Let's have a cup of coffee. (a) shall we? (b) will we? (c) should we? (d) could we?

Clue to answer: Use rule 8.

Model Question 7

He didn't sense Obi's presence in the room, did he?
(a) Yes, he did (b) No, he did (c) Yes, he didn't (d) No, he didn't

Clue to answer: Here, you have both a statement (**he didn't sense Obi's presence in the room**) and a question **did he?** In a case like this, it is the latter part (and in this case, it is a question) that should be considered in bringing the second part of the tag.

Model Question 8

You can travel on your own, (a) isn't it? (b) can't you?
(c) wouldn't you? (d) shouldn't you?

Clue to answer: Use rule 1.

Model Question 9

He does not seem to know how to solve the problem,?
(a) doesn't he (b) does not he (c) does he not (d) does he

Clue to answer: See rule 2.

Model Question 10

Nowadays, many graduates are not well disposed to teaching,?
(a) do they? (b) they are? (c) aren't they? (d) are they?

Here, we have a **negative statement ... not well disposed**, to followed by a positive question.

PARTICIPIALS

Normally, a statement will start showing the subject (the doer or actor) and then, go on to say what he/she/they do. But, when the identity of the subject is postponed till the second clause, it is a participial and it can come in any of the following ways:

1. **Having + past participle verb**, e.g. Having succeeded, (clause 1) he (subject) got a good job. (Note that in the first clause, there is no subject.)
2. **Starting with a gerund**, e.g. **Dancing** all day, he failed his examinations. (Subject appears in clause 2, not in clause 1)
3. **Using past participle**, e.g. **Defeated**, (clause 1) the boxer resigned. (clause 2)
4. **Using prepositional force**, e.g. **Concerning** that, the game is as good as lost.
5. **Using non-finite clauses**, e.g. If **talking** on that, we are better than them.

GENERAL RULE

When the first statement without the subject is mentioned, the second clause should start with the name or identity of the thing or person that is being talked about in the first clause, e.g. Walking down the street: (clause 1)

- (a) The car killed the boy.
- (b) The boy was killed by a car.

Which is right? **B**, of course. Ask yourself: walking down the street... who was walking down the street? the **car** or the **boy**? The second clause should start with **the boy** or his real name, not with information regarding the car. It would be another case to say: Speeding along the road.. (then it will be "the car killed the boy").

Model Question 1

.....for the team for six years, he decided to join another.
(a) When he played (b) Playing (c) Having played (d) In playing
(e) When he was playing

Clue to answer: Note that your answer must include having + a participle. Use rule 1.

Model Question 2

Walking down the street,..... (a) the boy was knocked down by a car. (b) a car knocked the boy down. (c) the boy was knocked down by car. (d) a car collided with the boy. (e) a serious accident happened.

Clue to answer: Who 'walked down the street'? **a car OR the boy?** Whichever you choose here should start the answer to this question.

Watch it not to pick (c). C is wrong because any time you mention a noun, there should be a determiner before it. It should have been a car. Other determiners are: **an, the, some, this, these, those, that, my, your, our, their, its, several, many, more, most, much, few, a few, little, a little, a great deal of, a lot of** etc..

This law does not apply to nouns used in their generic forms, e.g. **Man** (meaning male and female generally) as opposed to **A Man** (that I saw yesterday).

Model Question 3

..... the medicine, he asked his daughter to take it according to the doctor's prescription. (a) Having to buy (b) Having bought (c) Having been bought (d) Having being bought (e) Having buy

Clue to answer: Use rule 1.

Model Question 4

..... to help him, being the only person in the vicinity. (a) It was not possible (b) **There** was no one (c) **He** had nobody (d) **No** person was around

Clue to answer: The answer stands out clearly. Concerning the second clause, who was the only person in the vicinity – **He** or **There** or **No** or **It** ?

Model Question 5

On getting to the seashore, (a) it was empty. (b) nobody was there. (c) people had deserted the place. (d) he found nobody there.

Clue to answer: Use rule 4. Who got to the seashore?

Model Question 6

..... told of his impending arrival, I worked hard to make his short stay very comfortable. (a) Have I been (b) Have being (c) Having been (d) Having being

Clue to answer: See rule 1. Note that the difference between options c and d, is **been** and **being**. You have already learnt that, anywhere you find **has**, **have** (**having**) or **had**, if you are to make a choice between **being** and **been**, it should be **been**. However, **is** **was**, **are**, **were**, **am** can come before **being**.

TRANSITIVE VERBS

When you open your dictionary to a lexical verb, in front of it, you will find written either, **vt** or **vi**. While the former means **transitive verb**, the latter stands for **intransitive verb**.

A **verb** is **transitive** if it **requires** an **object** in front of it. You cannot, for example, say: I enjoyed or I slapped. In each case you must enjoy something or slap something/somebody. Such verbs that must compel you to pass their actions on to something or somebody are transitive. Those that do not require any object are intransitive verbs.

However, a verb may be both transitive and intransitive, so, watch out, when you come across words like the following: **ask, beat, boil, believe, break, open, point, raise, seem, set, suppose, think, turn, want, wash, wish, enjoy, give, teach, catch, offend, cast, lack, mean, weigh, resemble**.

This is by no means an exhaustive list since hundreds of verbs are in this category but the most common are those listed.

EXTRA GRAMMATICAL ENTRIES (I) IDIOMS

What do the following mean?

1. Tola has a **bee in her bonnet**.
2. Everyone has now started to **call into question** the teacher's knowledge.
3. They **keep an open house** on Sundays.

The meaning of idiomatic expressions cannot be determined from the words of the expression, e.g. **He shed crocodile tears** does not mean that there was a crocodile somewhere. It is just a kind of expression that is formed based on certain principles.

The Chemistry of idioms:

Idioms have at least two elements even as we have in Chemistry. We want to see how they combine to form a compound.

Idioms have two parts: A and B, A being compared to B to bring out the meaning, using the following levels of comparison:

(a) **Metaphors**

A metaphor is, comparing something with another sharply as in:

- (i) There are some **bad eggs** in the police. (imagine how a bad egg smells)
- (ii) The story is a **parrot's cry**. (a parrot raises undue alarm)
- (iii) **As the crow flies**. (the crow flies in a straight line)

(b) **Images/Imagery**

An image is a mental idea which one has about something said, seen, heard, smelt or touched, e.g:

- (i) **He received a pat on the back**. (just see the mental implication of someone patting another one on the back-it means approval)

- (ii) A land that flows with **milk and honey**. (if you know the taste of these two things, you will know the answer)

(c) **Symbols**

Symbols are a way of communicating without saying much or actually what is meant, using certain codes. There are different types of symbols namely:

(i) **Nature Symbols**

Rose (flower) shows **beauty** and **love**. **Fire** means **suffering** or **trouble**, as in (from frying pan to fire). **Water** is for **blessing** or **trouble**, depending on the context: when I saw the policeman, knew I was in **deep waters**. **Desert** signifies **sterility** and **unproductiveness**. **Lily** represents **death**. **Moon** (because of its unstable nature) represents **inconstancy** and **inconsistency**.

(ii) **Colour Symbols**

- White** – **purity, innocence, unproductiveness** as in **white elephant project**
- Yellow** – **jealousy, cowardice**: When he saw the teacher coming with a cane, he grew **yellow**.
- Blue** – **wealth, trouble**.
- Black** – **evil, sorrow**.
- Red** – **important** as in **red-letter day, red carpet reception**. It also means **danger**.
- green** – **life, strength**.

(iii) **Animal Symbols**

- Lion** – **greatness, bigness**.
- Elephant** – **bigness**.
- Dog** – **poverty, gentleness**.
- Goat** – **stubbornness and aggressiveness**.
- Sheep** – **dependence, lack of sense**
- Eagle** – **strength** as in **he is eagle eyed clever; protective**
- Owl** – **evil omen**.
- Cat** – **cleverness**.

Monkey	-	agility.
Serpent	-	deceit, evil,
Bat	-	Inconsistency.

(iv) **Others**

Crown – Royalty.

Cross – problem; suffering.

Here is a list of idiomatic expressions and their meanings.

1. There is a **backlog** of salaries to be paid to the workers - **arrears**.
2. Instead of working hard, Dende **banks on** his father's wealth - **relies on**.
3. Angela was **killed in cold blood** - **killed deliberately**.
4. Akin is a **chip off the old block** - **resembles his father**.
5. Ola usually **sticks out his neck** - **does what could bring him problems**.
6. I do not like to **take a shot in the dark** - **guess at something suspected**.
7. The robbers **had a raw deal** in the hands of the police last night - **unfair/harsh treatment**.
8. Some musicians **make a splash** with love music - **attract people's attention**.
9. Johnson talks like a book - **does things or speaks in an awkward manner**.
10. Our economy is at a **low ebb** - **in a bad state**.
11. It is not advisable to make a **hollow truce** in business - **unsigned agreement**.
12. The president advised us to **take heart** - **have courage**.
13. She said she received **first hand information** about the man's death - **directly from the source**.
14. Tola is a girl that **catches my eye** - **that I am attracted to**.

15. It is not good to **tread on people's toes** in order to find favour – **offend people**.
16. The students agreed that their examination was not a **walk-over – easy**.
17. Bode told me **point-blank** that he could drive - **plainly**.
18. Cunning lawyers usually **beat around the bush** – do not **come straight to the point**.
19. Last Sunday was a **red-letter day** for me – a memorable day.
20. To cross a road without looking both ways is **playing with fire** – **toying with what could bring misfortune**.
21. The Professor submitted a huge manuscript after **picking his student's brain** – asking him a lot of questions to **gain knowledge**.
22. Looking for small snails to make his food, Ade left no stone unturned – **made all efforts necessary**.
23. In times of trouble, a man should **take the bull by the horns** – **face the situation boldly**.
24. When the robbers besieged our house, we knew we were in **the wood** – **in danger**.
25. The pretty girl **had words with** her grandmother over the choice of her husband – **quarrelled with**.
26. Almost every old person knows how to **put issues across** more gently – **explain things without offending anybody**.
27. Zogo recited off the poem **as clean as a whistle** – **perfectly**.
28. When I came from London, my friends **tided me over** – **helped me make a temporary arrangement**.
29. Mother said she was **put out** by our action – **upset**.
30. Mature men and women do not find it difficult to **rub shoulders** – **interact**.
31. The relationship between the secretary and the manager is **on the rocks** – **heading towards failure**.
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32. Once an argument has started, a good lawyer should not **shift his ground – change his opinion.**
33. Politics in Nigeria **is well under way – making good progress.**
34. When the car's brake failed it became **touch and go – risky.**
35. Food is always the **bone of contention** whenever students go on rampage – **subject of disagreement.**
36. Women can be given a **pride of place** in politics if they prove capable – **the greatest prominence.**
37. A debater cannot afford to **sit on the fence – be neutral.**
38. People should **set their house in order** before criticizing others – **put their own affairs straight.**
39. Cocoa farmers are now **feeling the pinch – experiencing painful consequences.**
40. Our President is good at **playing his card very close to his chest – not showing his intentions.**
41. **Matters came to a head** last week when the couple fought – reached a crisis.
42. Many Africans **live from hand to mouth – have no savings.**
43. His ideas were **watered down by his boss – weakened or made less effective.**
44. Smoking cigarettes is a **thin end of the wedge – one new habit/thing leading to a more dangerous one.**
45. Sixty percent of Nigerians **have a stake** in one firm or the other – **important share or part.**
46. Choosing strict invigilators will help to **close the loopholes** in examination malpractice – **block opportunity for cheating.**
47. One should not reject an idea **out of hand - at once.**
48. The Principal of the school was **rapped over the knuckles – criticised.**

49. No student ever liked to be sent to Coventry – ostracized/
removed from others.
50. The messenger was given a short shrift by the Panel – not
given much regard or consideration.
51. His latest album has been given a good press – favoured
by newspaper reports.
52. Once a decision is taken, execution should not be shelved
– postponed.
53. It is common knowledge that the man is good – generally
accepted.
54. This plan falls between two stools – fails, not
accomplishing any of the two alternative situations.
55. Everything was at sixes and sevens – in confusion.
56. They are not able to make ends meet – manage their
income.
57. Everyone now takes his information with a pinch of salt –
they do not believe him anymore.
58. The new Manager is a square peg in a round hole –
unsuited for the job.
59. We should be hand in glove with one another – close
partners (who work together in a dubious enterprise).
60. The complainant has no leg to stand on – cannot support
his claim.
61. The Pastor hit the nail on the head – said the right thing.
62. They are all in the same boat – in the same difficult
situation.
63. I called his bluff – challenged him to do what he
threatened.
64. Husbands and wives should be able to put all their cards
on the table – be completely open about their plans.
65. The rank and file of the ministry are angry – ordinary low-
level staff members.

66. Candidates should **read between the lines** when dealing with comprehension passages – **look out for hidden meaning.**
67. Women should not be trusted with delicate situations; they whimsically **spill the beans** – **reveal secrets.**
68. When he told us that his father died, we were not **taken aback** – **surprised.**
69. My iron box now works **off and on** – **at intervals, not regular.**
70. Pamby is nothing but a **stick-in-the-mud** – **dependent, unadventurous fellow.**
71. Wendy hit a **sore point** with her grand-mother – **struck a sensitive part of the matter.**
72. There are no **short cuts** in English but many in Mathematics. – **quicker methods (of doing things).**
73. When Mr Andrew's wealthy wife slapped him, he **pocketed his pride** – **took it without protest.**
74. At 20, Ada had been able to **weather the storm** – **overcome difficulties.**
75. Not all grown ups could **fend for themselves** – **provide what they need.**
76. The old man talked as if he were **all there** – **was mentally alert and strong.**
77. She is a **dyed in the wool** prostitute – **hardened.**
78. Almost all soldiers have **case-hardened** views about life – **unscrupulous and wicked.**
79. For an Englishman to assume African culture is a **tall order** – **difficult thing to do.**
80. Prompoh is **tied to her mother's apron strings** – **dependent upon her mother.**
81. He shed **crocodile tears** for the dead old man – **insincere tears.**

82. She went **from frying pan to fire** – bad to worse situations
83. An idea of wealth without sweat is **wishful thinking** – a **false unreal hope**.
84. The little boy spoke English **like a house on fire** – easily and **effortlessly**.
85. A child's decaying teeth should be **nipped in the bud** – **stopped from the beginning**.
86. A lot of Christians **pay lip service** to God – give **false impression of love for God**.
87. He began his footballing career **like a duck to water** – **quickly and lovingly**.
88. The chairman opined that members should **get off the beaten track** – **look for new methods**.
89. Their stay in America was **nothing to write home about** – **not remarkable**.
90. The mischievous girl often **makes a mountain out of a mole-hill** – **exaggerates things**.
91. Did you say you would **go in with me** to the supermarket – **support me financially**.
92. Almost all civil servants **burn a hole in their pockets** in a few days – **spend all they have**.
93. I have **burnt my boat**, Allen said – **made up his mind about something**.
94. All he said was mere **window-dressing** – **false impression**.
95. He often **blows his own trumpet** – **praises himself**.
96. They usually **play their tune to the gallery** – **do things in order to be praised or loved**.
97. The prefect's **wings were clipped** after the riot – **his power was reduced**.
98. After his father's death, Sola **came to grips with the situation** – **understood and dealt with the problem**.

99. Dupe promised to **put her back into** passing the test – **do work extremely hard**.
100. We were **hit below the belt** in the panel's judgment – **treated unfairly**.
101. Yemisi **turns in her coat** as many times as occasion demands – **changes her principles**.
102. The Pastor advised us to **mind our p's and q's** – **be careful about our behaviour**.
103. Nike is quick at **raising the wind** – **making money**.
104. Last year, I had a **close shave** on my way to Lagos – a **narrow escape**.
105. Everyone should try to **hold his/her peace** – **raise no objection**.
106. When the policeman saw me, I **kicked up a row** – **started a disturbance; complained**.
107. Laide told me that she **felt her ear burning** – **suspected somebody was discussing her unfairly**.
108. He gave a **chapter and verse** for his answer – **factors to prove his answer**.
109. My opinion **flies in the face of** the president's – **is contrary to**.
110. Mary usually **digs in** after saying her prayers – **eats**.
111. Sade told me she bought a **pig in a poke** – **bought what she had not seen**.
112. 'We cannot **stand guard** again,' the man yelled – **watch for attack**.
113. There are **hard and fast rules** of English – **firmly fixed**.
114. He arrived the examination hall at the **eleventh hour** – **when almost late**.
115. He promised to **make good** his promises – **fulfill**.
116. After ten years of laziness, Oni has now **made good** – **succeeded**.
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117. The young teacher is in the principal's good graces – is liked by the principal.
118. His University admission will open the door to his prosperity – be the beginning of.
119. The meeting was held behind closed doors – with no outsider present.
120. After spending a huge amount on Ade's education, his father knew his money had gone down the drain – was wasted.
121. The politician reiterated his ability to deliver the goods – perform up to expectation.
122. The man is simple to a fault – greatly or extremely simple.
123. Not a single person can have a go at the dubious plan – attempt.
124. When his wife died, he knew his life would fall flat – be less exciting.
125. Boye is really not cut out for music – does not have the talent to be a musician.
126. Most painters have an eye for aesthetics – are good at noticing aesthetics.
127. In business, it is advisable to draw a line between personal money and contributions – identify a limit.
128. The two villages agreed to bury the hatchet – stop fighting.
129. The weaker fighter came holding out an olive branch – suing/clamouring for peace.
130. The cashier is a cog in the wheel of the company's progress – disturbance.
131. My wife, though a woman, is my right hand man – someone I rely upon.
132. The farmer had some hands on his farm – workmen.
133. When the war broke up, some people ran helter skelter – in confused hurry.

134. He is **above board** in his dealing – honest, trustworthy and clever.
135. The new hotel was **razed to the ground** – destroyed by fire.
136. When we quarrelled, I gave him a **wide berth** – stopped coming in contact with him.
137. When he was tired, Andrew **threw in the towel/sponge** – surrendered.
138. She was born with **blue blood** in her veins – into a wealthy family, also with a **silver spoon** in her mouth.
139. Most traders **line their pockets** after selling far above market price – **make abnormal profit** in dishonest ways.
140. Our company may not **break-even** until next year – **start to realise profit**.
141. My bank account is **in the black** – contains a lot of money (in the red means bankrupt).
142. Going back on my decision is **out of the question**, he said – **not practicable**.
143. When the villagers **let the cat out the bag**, the robbers were arrested – **revealed the secret**.
144. The Governor made the inspection to see how the land lies – **assess the situation of things**.
145. All trains move at a **snail's pace** – very slowly.
146. My house is a **stone's throw** from the police station – very close.
147. James was described as a **wet blanket** – one who discourages others.
148. Valentine **takes a dim view of farming** – disapproves.

EXTRA GRAMMATICAL ENTRIES (II)

CLICHÉS

Can you attempt to say what any of the following expressions means?

- (a) He had his **baptism of fire** yesterday.
- (b) There was a **battle royal** at Andrew street yesterday.
- (c) There are several **belted earls** in our society.
- (d) The girl has **blue blood** in her veins.
- (e) The answer was arrived at by **rule of thumb**.
- (f) The **city fathers** have been asked to go to jail.
- (g) It is easy to give a **counsel of perfection**.
- (h) The teacher **crossed the Styx** this morning.
- (i) **Feline amenities** should not be taken seriously.
- (j) The boy said he could not thank the little **girl for the life of him**.

The emboldered expressions, and many more like them, are called **clichés**. Once you know them, you know them and if you don't, you may not be able to put them in meaningful contexts and you would not determine their meanings from the way they are used. You must learn them.

A **cliché** is a stereotyped expression; a common place phrase invented one or two centuries ago that is now old and hackneyed because of overuse. This notwithstanding, examiners test you on them.

In this treatise, **clichés** have been explained and even exemplified in sentences to bring home their real meanings to the reader.

1. **To be unable to make head or tail of something** means to **understand nothing about that thing**, e.g. Since there was chaos, the police could not make head or tail of the robbery.

2. To have an ace up one's sleeve means – to have something of worth in reserve, e.g. Having won a scholarship, Ade now has an ace up his sleeve.

3. Achilles' heel/the heel of Achilles = The weak spot or one's weak point, e.g. Olu is obedient but his Achilles' heel is arrogance.

4. The acid test – A very severe and determining test.

5. To act in cold blood = to do something cruel, especially to someone else, e.g. The police claimed that the man killed his wife in cold blood.

6. To add insult to injury = to displease a person and still insult him, e.g. To beat and detain an innocent citizen is to add insult to injury.

7. After one's heart = that one admires or likes, e.g. Tola is a lady after the young man's heart.

8. Again and again = repeatedly, frequently, e.g. The Pastor warned the congregation against unholy behaviour again and again.

9. Airy nothings = to make useless, empty remarks, e.g. Only those who do not know Oye make airy nothings about him.

10. Alive and kicking – healthy and active, e.g. When rumours that the king had died reached him, he told people that he was alive and kicking.

11. All and sundry – Everybody together and individually, e.g. The problem should be a concern to all and sundry.

12. All in a lifetime = happening to everybody, e.g. Experiencing insults is all in a lifetime.

13. Almost incredible – Hard to believe, e.g. It is almost incredible that the soldiers killed him.

14. **Alpha and Omega** = highly learned; the beginning and the end, e.g. People like Dr Okolo are rare – he is Alpha and Omega in surgical circles.
15. **Ample opportunity** = various, many opportunities, e.g. The holiday will give the students ample opportunities to make some money before they return to school.
16. **Appear on the scene** = to arrive/show up, e.g. The armed robbers had disappeared before the police appeared on the scene.
17. **Appear to be without foundations** = it is a rumour, baseless unestablished, information, e.g. That the innocent looking woman is a thief appears to be without foundation.
18. **Apple of discord** = a source of disagreement / something common place, e.g. To pay money is usually an apple of discord even between friends.
19. **Apple of one's eye** = something precious to one, e.g. When finally the woman bought her own house, it became the apple of her eye.
20. **Apron strings** = under the influence of somebody, e.g. Sade cannot take decisions on her own – she is still tied to her mother's apron strings.
21. **Argus-eyed** = highly watchful, sensitive or vigilant, e.g. After the riots, the police became Argus eyed.
22. **Armed to the teeth** = fully equipped with ammunition of war, e.g. It is difficult to encroach upon the man's house – his guards are armed to the teeth.
23. **As man to man** = frankly or with friendliness, e.g. Ade got enough courage to discuss his problems with the manager as man to man.
24. **As one** = done together, especially an action, e.g. No society can succeed if things are not seen and done as one.

25. **As the crow flies** = in a straight or direct line without obstruction, e.g. The parading soldiers now stand as the crow flies.
26. **At a loose end** = to be idle, e.g. After being retrenched, Ola's mother was, for a long time, at a loose end.
27. **At death's door/ to bring to death's door** = to be seriously ill (not sick), e.g. It surprised us that he survived because he had been at death's door.
28. **At long last** = finally, in the end (not at the end), e.g. The chairman vied for the presidency eight times and at long last, he won.
29. **At one's last gasp** = at the point or hour of death, e.g. The lawyer made his will at his last gasp.
30. **At one's wit's end** = to be confused and be unable to decide what to do, e.g. Having tried all methods of handling the problems in vain, the engineer came to his wit's end.
31. **At a person's own sweet will** = at the time that pleases one, e.g. We can see you at our own sweet will – can't we?
32. **At sixes and sevens** = a state of perplexity or utter confusion or chaos or, even negligence, e.g. Everybody saw that Mrs. Obi was at sixes and sevens on the day her husband died.
33. **At cross-roads** = at an important point of one's life or career, e.g. After her education, Grace came to the cross roads.
34. **At the end of one's tether** = to be completely weak physically, psychologically and monetarily, e.g. Having lost his job and, being at the same time ill, Johny told us that he was the end of his tether.
35. **Atmosphere of doubt** = a general – not particular – feeling of doubt, e.g. When the treasurer told us that he was robbed of the Association's money, there was an atmosphere of doubt.

36. **At this juncture (not junction)** = at this important point, e.g. I am now going to talk about 'honesty' and, at this juncture, I shall give examples.
37. **Axe to grind/have no axe to grind** = to be interested or not to be interested, e.g. The students said they had no axe to grind with stale issues of government.
38. **Back the wrong horse** = to support an unworthy cause, to favour the wrong thing, e.g. The public have been misguided by the Chairman's address and they have decided to back the wrong horse of corruption.
39. **Bag and baggage** = with all one's belongings, e.g. The Indians left their country, bag and baggage.
40. **Balmy breeze/balmy weather** = soft, pleasant breeze or weather.
41. **Baptism of fire** = to experience the shot of bullets, directed to one, e.g. When the robbers came face-to-face with the police, their leader had a baptism of fire.
42. **Battle royal** = a free-for-all fight/a general thing, e.g. At the town hall on Monday, the police stopped a battle royal.
43. **Be in good hands** – to be well catered for and kindly looked after, e.g. Her husband being a doctor, the sick woman was in good hands.
44. **Be in the same boat with** = to experience the same things as someone else, e.g. "Look, Tunde," Akin said, "that you are seriously seeking university admission is not unique to you. We are in the same boat."
45. **Be that as it may** = that notwithstanding; in spite of that, e.g. Joy's father died when she was young, be that as it may she managed to finish her elementary school.
46. **Bear the brunt** = to suffer the most unpleasant part of a struggle or battle, e.g. Having started the riots, the students bore the brunt of their actions.

47. **Beat about the bush** = to be incoherent and inexact, to be short of words for expression of what one wishes, e.g. Instead of giving an accurate account of the event, the historian only beat about the bush.
48. **Beaten at the post** – defeated or overcome when success is almost completely achieved, e.g. No JAMB candidate should relent his/her efforts, lest such be beaten at the post.
49. **Bed of roses** – resting, comfortable point or place, e.g. "Life," people have always said, "is not a bed of roses."
50. **Beginning of a new era** = a historic period when great things have happened or about to happen, e.g. The death of the elder statesman is the beginning of a new era.
51. **Beginning of the end** = the initial time in the process of failure decay or damage, e.g. Immediately Dele came face-to-face with Mr. Tyson in a bout, Dele knew it was the beginning of the end of him.
52. **Behind the scenes** = with nobody looking at one in private; not open to the public, e.g. Every man is holy in the public eye but what individuals do behind the scenes is usually despicable.
53. **Believe one's eye/cannot believe...** = find it difficult to accept what one has seen, e.g. When the little boys were electrocuted last week, their father could not believe his eyes as he saw their corpses.
54. **Belong to a world apart/live a world apart** = to be of a higher social class than others, e.g. Bimbo rarely went to his classmates' homes as he belonged to a world apart.
55. **Belted earl** = an affluent, wealthy person, e.g. The gold merchant along Lagere Street is, no doubt, a belted earl.
56. **Beneath contempt** = very much open to ridicule and disgrace, e.g. When she failed her examinations, she came beneath contempt.

57. **Benefit of the doubt** = to treat somebody as innocent because there is doubt in evidence against him, e.g. Since the principal witness was dead, the murder accused was given the benefit of the doubt.
58. **Better half** = one's wife, e.g. I shall travel in December with my better half.
59. **Between the cup and the lip** = the period between the planning of something and its finishing or realization, e.g. The project which is now between the cup and lip should not fail, the Engineer said.
60. **Between the devil and the deep sea** = between two dangers, e.g. When the robbers told me "your money or your life", I knew I was between the devil and the deep sea. It also means, to be in a dilemma.
61. **Between two fires** = open to abuse, insult, assault or danger, e.g. When the little boy stole his teacher's money, he got between two fires.
62. **Between you and me and the bed-post** = (esp. of a matter) said in confidence or told and kept between only two people, as secret, e.g. That I killed the man should be between you and me and the bed-post.
63. **Beyond a shadow of doubt** = that is, certainly sure, e.g. Beyond a shadow of doubt, I will repay the money next week.
64. **Beyond belief** = that should not be believed, e.g. it is beyond belief that an African-American cannot become American President.
65. **Bird of ill-omen** = a person that brings evil or a curse e.g. Jonah the prophet was a bird of ill omen.
66. **Birds of a feather (not "birds of the same" feather)** = two things or people that are alike, e.g. Yemi and Bimpe are always absent from school, they are birds of a feather.

67. **Bite off more than one can chew** = to do something which is beyond one's power, e.g. When Henshaw married the wealthy woman, everybody knew that he had bitten more than he could chew.
68. **Blank despair** = a completely hopeless situation, e.g. when her husband was imprisoned, Mrs Ijimere was in blank despair.
69. **Blaze a/the trail** = to be the first person to do something, e.g. The Wright brothers blazed the trail in aeronautics, when they invented the first aeroplane.
70. **Blood and iron (with)** = using military power or force instead of the milder approach of diplomacy and tactics, e.g. Our country is now being run with blood and with iron.
71. **Blow hot and cold** = to be, at one time highly vivacious and spirited, and at another, be gloomy and sad, e.g. Veronica is a strange girl; she blows hot and cold.
72. **Blow one's own trumpet** = to praise or advertise oneself, e.g. Politicians are a category of people who know how to blow their own trumpets.
73. **Blue blood** – wealthy, affluent, aristocratic blood, e.g. Merely looking at her face could show she has blue blood in her veins.
74. **Bolt from the blue** = unexpected misfortune, e.g. The Nigerian team losing to Saudi's was a bolt from the blue.
75. **Bone of contention** = The point that brings argument or controversy or disagreement, e.g. The detention of innocent citizens is the bone of contention of the students' peaceful demonstration.
76. **Boot is on the other leg** = the case has been changed and that it is the other person to defend himself, e.g. Having proved himself innocent, the first driver was discharged and acquitted of dangerous driving while the boot was on the other leg.
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77. **Born and bred** = born and reared (in a place), e.g. Dada was born and bred in his mother's village.
78. **Born with a silver spoon in one's mouth** = born at a time of prosperity – or into a prosperous family e.g. The only child of the wealthy man was born with a silver spoon in his mouth.
79. **Borrowed plumes** = something which does not belong to one but which has won glory for one, e.g. To use quotations in speeches brings applause based on borrowed plumes.
80. **Brand of Cain** = murderer, e.g. When the robber was brought to court, the judge called him a "brand of Cain".
81. **Break the ice** – prepare the way for something or to make a beginning, e.g. Johnson broke the ice by introducing himself as "J.J." to the pretty girl.
82. **Breathed freely** = to be at liberty after danger or disturbance, e.g. Nigerians now breathe freely.
83. **Breathe one's last** = to die, e.g. Nobody prays to breathe his last through an accident.
84. **Bring grist to one's mill** = to get a very lucrative job, e.g. His employment with the oil firm has brought grist to his mill.
85. **Bring home to** = to help make someone realize something, e.g. This small book will bring what JAMB wants every candidate to know, home to them.
86. **Bring somebody to his knees** = to humble, trivialize or make sober or dejected, e.g. If a candidate uses this book well, he or she will surely bring JAMB to its knees.
87. **Broken reed** = a person upon which one may not rely, e.g. Bola, by nature, is a broken reed.
88. **Buld castles in the air** = create hopes that may never be realized, e.g. To think that one could live affluently without hard work is building castles in the air.

89. **Build upon sand** = to do something without adequate preparations, or secure beginning, e.g. Lovers should not hurry into marriage, otherwise, the union will be built upon sand.
90. **Bulwark of the state** = a truly great statesman, e.g. Just a few people could be described as bulwarks of the state.
91. **Bundle of nerves** = to be very nervous, e.g. Toyin is so moody today: she is simply a bundle of nerves.
92. **Burn one's boat** = to make up one's mind and stand his decisions, e.g. Wherever Ayo made a personal policy he would tell his friends that he had burnt his boats.
93. **Burn one's fingers** = to harm oneself, e.g. Those who take alcohol burn their own fingers.
94. **Burn the candle at both ends** = to work early and late or to work hard and play hard, e.g. The students take ill frequently because they burn the candle at both ends.
95. **Burn the midnight oil** = to study through the night – Not all those who burn the midnight oil usually come off well in tests.
96. **Burning question** – something that brings argument, e.g. Racial discrimination in South Africa is surely a burning question.
97. **Bury the hatchet** = stop quarrelling, e.g. The two groups agreed to bury the hatchet.
98. **But me no buts** = do not argue or object, e.g. "I have asked you to shoot," the commander said, "and you should but me no buts."
99. **Buy a pig in a poke** = to negotiate for / take possession of / buy something which one has not seen, e.g. It amounts to big losses to buy a pig in a poke.
100. **By fits and starts** = at irregular periods or intervals, intermittently, e.g. The baby cries by fits and starts everyday.

101. **By hook or by crook (not by hook or crook)** = by all possible means; at all costs, e.g. The students cheated in the examination because they wanted to pass by hook or by crook.
102. **By leaps and bounds** = to go ahead progressively or rapidly, e.g. The number of JAMB candidates increases every year by leaps and bounds.
103. **By no manner of means** = that is, NO, not acceptable, e.g. When the teacher asked the student whether he understood the lecture, the student said "by no manner of means."
104. **By rule of thumb** = unscientific, crude or non-standard way, e.g. The English Language does not operate by rule of thumb.
105. **By the same token** = In the same way, e.g. Mary shook Dennis' hands and, by the same token, Dennis kissed her passionately.
106. **By the sweat of one's brow** = by hard, manual effort/labour, e.g. The grass on our playing field is usually cut by the sweat of the students' brow.
107. **By word of mouth** = orally, e.g. The message was delivered to us by word of mouth.
108. **Call to a halt** = to stop something or desist from something e.g. The police commissioner has tried in vain to call bribery to a halt among his men.
109. **Call a spade a spade** = to call a thing by the real name without showing unnecessary favour by using mild language or euphemism, e.g. The Pastor called adulterers sinners; he always calls a spade a spade
110. **Captain of Industry** = controller or manager of big industrial business, e.g. Some captains of industry were cautioned by government last June.